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Govt clears ₹658 crore road upgrade projects



NATION: Pg 4

DGCA acts as AI flight strays into Pak airspace



FILM: Pg 12

'Elle Woods always takes the high road'

IRAN'S NUCLEAR SITES

Deal first, inspections later

UN nuclear agency boss expects site visits under interim pact | Iran insists on final deal first

ASSOCIATED PRESS

TOKYO: The head of the UN's nuclear agency signalled Wednesday that Iranian nuclear enrichment sites would be visited by his inspectors, a key component in the interim deal between the United States and Iran to reach an end to the war.

The comment by International Atomic Energy Agency (IAEA) head Rafael Mariano Grossi was the firmest yet from the United Nations agency, which is viewed as key in determining the status of Iran's nuclear stockpile.

Since Israel launched a 12-day war on Iran in 2025, the IAEA has been blocked by Tehran from visiting enrichment sites where the Islamic Republic is believed to store enough highly enriched uranium to potentially build as many as 10 nuclear weapons, should it choose to rush for the bomb. Iran long has maintained that its program is peaceful, though it is the only country in the world to have uranium enriched up to 60 per cent purity without a weapons program.



Maryam al-Ghul holds a picture of her husband, Hezbollah fighter Zain al-Abidin Qubaisi, who was killed in battle against Israel, as she stands on the rubble of her family's house in the town of Nabatieh, southern Lebanon, on Wednesday

AP/PTI

HIGHLIGHTS

» Since Israel launched a 12-day war on Iran in 2025, the IAEA has been blocked by Tehran from visiting enrichment sites

» Iran long has maintained that its program is peaceful, though it is the only country in the world to have uranium enriched up to 60 per cent purity without a weapons program

» The US and Iran offered contradictory remarks Tuesday about whether those sites would be inspected. Grossi acknowledged the contradictions, calling it a 'war of words' at the moment

» An Iranian diplomat rejected comments on Wednesday by the head of the IAEA, saying nuclear site inspections would only be possible after a final US-Iran deal

PM MODI INVITED TO KHAMENEI'S FUNERAL

NEW DELHI: Iranian President Masoud Pezeshkian is learnt to have invited Prime Minister Narendra Modi to the burial ceremonies for the late Supreme Leader Ayatollah Ali Khamenei, diplomatic sources said on Wednesday.

The funeral ceremonies will be held from July 5 to 9. There is no confirmation from New Delhi on the invitation to PM Modi. Khamenei, who ruled Iran for three decades, was killed on February 28, the first day of massive US and Israeli air strikes on Tehran. The funeral is slated to be held in Tehran and Qom on July 5, 6, and 7. The final ceremony will take place in the city of Mashhad on July 9.

MPOST

Gaza war claims over 20K children

UNITED NATIONS: More than 20,000 Palestinian children have been killed by Israeli forces in "deliberate, targeted" attacks since October 2023, according to a UN commission of inquiry chaired by Srinivasan Muralidhar.

Muralidhar, the former Orissa High Court Chief Justice, said in a press conference in Geneva on Tuesday that

they found "indisputable evidence" concerning the "deliberate, targeted killing of Palestinian children, including since the October 2025 ceasefire".

Israel rejected the report and called it a "libelous sham". "The COI is a fundamentally flawed mechanism whose very purpose is to single out and vilify Israel rather than seek the truth," it said.

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POST-MORTEM REVEALS SMOKE INHALATION CAUSED ALL 15 DEATHS

Lucknow fire victims died suffocating

CHANDAN KUMAR/PTI

LUCKNOW: The 15 people killed in the fire that tore through a building in Lucknow's Aliganj didn't have major burn injuries and suffocated to death after inhaling large quantities of smoke, according to the post-mortem report.

There was no clear evidence of extensive burn injuries or deep wounds that could directly explain the deaths, doctors associated with the post-mortem said.

However, the doctors observed swelling around the faces and eyes of several victims and detected soot and smoke particles inside their nasal passages -- an indication that they had inhaled large quantities of smoke before their deaths.



A woman takes a picture at the site as the Lucknow Development Authority (LDA) team issues a demolition notice for the three-storey commercial building at the Aliganj area

PTI

"The post-mortem examination has revealed that all 15 victims died due to suffocation

caused by smoke inhalation. No major burn injuries or grievous external wounds were found that

could be attributed as the direct cause of death," a senior doctor involved in

Continued on P4

TRAPPED IN SMOKE

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» However, the doctors observed swelling around the faces and eyes of several victims and detected soot and smoke particles inside their nasal passages -- an indication that they had inhaled large quantities of smoke before their deaths

» Based on the findings, doctors concluded that all 15 victims died due to asphyxiation caused by smoke inhalation

Nirav faces \$11m bill

PRESS TRUST OF INDIA

LONDON: Fugitive diamond merchant Nirav Modi is liable to pay Bank of India over \$11.5 million, including accruing interest on a personal loan guarantee, the High Court in London has ruled.

The 55-year-old jeweller, who remains in prison fighting extradition to India in a separate \$2 billion Punjab National Bank (PNB) fraud and money laundering case, had disputed the enforceability of the personal guarantee related to a loan to a Dubai-incorporated firm, Firestar Diamond FZE, associated with him.

In a judgment handed down at the London Circuit Commercial Court on Tuesday, Justice Simon Tinkler found in favour of the Bank of India after a lengthy legal process complicated by paperwork transfer delays within the UK prison service.

"Mr Modi was validly served with the October 2025 Modi Demand.

Continued on P4

Taratala warehouse collapse kills five, many feared trapped

MPOST BUREAU

KOLKATA: The sound of buckling steel and collapsing concrete shattered the afternoon calm in Taratala on Wednesday as a warehouse roof collapsed. Hours later, amid the whirr of cranes and the shriek of gas cutters, rescuers were still straining to hear cries for help from beneath the wreckage where workers remained trapped under tonnes of debris. By evening, five deaths had been confirmed, 21 people rescued and authorities feared more victims could still be buried underneath.

The tragedy occurred around 12.07 pm on Transport Depot Road near Brace Bridge when the roof structure of an under-construction multi-storey warehouse and cold storage facility gave way during concrete casting work on the third floor. Witnesses reported hearing a deafening roar before the structure collapsed, trapping workers underneath.



The Syama Prasad Mookerjee Port Authority (SMPA) mobilised cranes, gas cutters, ambulances and medical teams. Firefighters, Civil Defence personnel and local residents

Continued on P4

CRPF DIG suspended over CAPF Bill posts

MPOST BUREAU

NEW DELHI: The CRPF has suspended a senior DIG-rank officer for sharing content allegedly "against" the government during the recent passage of the CAPF Bill, which the cadre officers of these forces had called discriminatory.

This is the first such case among the approximately 15,000 cadre officers entrusted with leadership roles in the country's 10-lakh-strong Central Armed Police Forces (CAPFs).

Officials identified the officer who faced action as Deputy Inspector General (DIG) B C Patra, posted at the force's Tripura Sector headquarters in Agartala.

The 1994-batch CRPF cadre officer returned to the Central Reserve Police Force (CRPF) in April after completing a deputation posting with the federal counter-terrorist commando force NSG.

Officials said Patra was suspended a few days ago under Sub-Rule (1) of Rule 10 of the CCS (CCA) Rules, 1965 pending a preliminary enquiry.

Continued on P4

IN REBUKE TO TRUMP OVER IRAN CONFLICT

Senate okays war powers resolution, a first

ASSOCIATED PRESS

WASHINGTON: The Senate for the first time approved a war powers resolution, seeking to block US military action against Iran, as lawmakers warily watch President Donald Trump's efforts to resolve a conflict that the administration launched on its own and now needs Congress to fund.

It was the 10th time the Senate has tried to stop the war, and the outcome, on a vote of 50-48 on Tuesday, was a stunning turnaround from past efforts.

While the resolution is largely symbolic, and does not carry the full force of law, it reflects the growing concerns from a number of Republican lawmakers in both the House and Senate over both the war and the deal Trump struck with Iran to end it. The House approved the resolution earlier this month.



Trump responded angrily Tuesday night on his Truth Social platform, calling the vote "poorly timed and meaningless" and saying it "provided aid and comfort" to Iran.

Senate Democratic Leader Chuck

Schumer of New York said, "Time after time, the vast majority of Senate Republicans sided with Trump and his war instead of the American people."

Schumer said Americans have paid the price for "Trump's historic blun-

der in Iran. It'll go down in the history books as one of the worst foreign policy forays America has ever made."

In the past, as many as four GOP senators have voted for the war powers resolutions, and they

Continued on P4

IRAN CONFLICT

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MONSOON MAYHEM



Commuters waded through a waterlogged road after heavy rainfall, in Mumbai, Maharashtra

PTI

Rain inspection turns dramatic

MUMBAI: A Brihanmumbai Municipal Corporation (BMC) supervisor fell into a water channel next to where Mayor Ritu Tawde was inspecting waterlogging in a Mumbai locality on Wednesday after overnight heavy rains.

A video of the incident, which took place at Gandhi Market in King's Circle area, went viral on social media, prompting opposition to slam the city's monsoon preparedness.

The BMC staffer, who fell into the water channel a few feet from where the mayor was standing, was immediately rescued.

See P6

Door row turns deadly on local

MUMBAI: A 22-year-old man was allegedly stabbed to death by a co-passenger on a Mumbai local train during an argument over whether the doors should be kept open amid the rains, in the second such incident this year, officials said on Wednesday.

The accused, subsequently identified as Sachin Ramesh Suvarna (30), was arrested hours later following a massive manhunt, which included the scanning of footage from nearly 400 CCTV cameras, an official said.

Victim Mayank Lohar was fatally assaulted by Suvarna inside a first-class compartment on Tuesday.

See P4

Passport is a travel document, not proof of citizenship: MEA

MPOST BUREAU

NEW DELHI: A passport is a travel document, not a citizenship certificate, the MEA said, highlighting biometric-enabled e-passports designed to enhance security and curb fraud, HT reported.

The external affairs ministry will organise a two-day Human Resource Mobility Forum next week to highlight legal pathways

for migration and facilitate networking between foreign employers and Indian nationals seeking jobs abroad, the officials said on the occasion of Passport Seva Divas, observed on June 24 to commemorate the enactment of the Passports Act in 1967.

The passport remains a travel document, and not a document of citizenship, as it attests the nationality of Indians when they

Continued on P4



GOVT WARNS AGAINST NEGLIGENCE COMPROMISING STUDENT SAFETY

Delhi govt orders safety audit of 923 coaching centres after Lucknow fire

OUR CORRESPONDENT

NEW DELHI: Two days after a massive fire in a Lucknow building claimed 15 lives, the Delhi government on Wednesday ordered a special inspection drive covering 923 coaching centres across the national capital to check compliance with fire safety and building norms.

The building, which caught on fire in Lucknow, housed an animation centre, among other establishments, and most of the victims who lost their lives were students.

Education Minister Ashish Sood directed the Delhi Development Authority (DDA), Municipal Corporation of Delhi (MCD), Delhi Fire Service and Delhi Disaster Management Authority (DDMA) to launch inspections at major coaching hubs, including Mukherjee Nagar, Rajender Nagar and Katwaria Sarai.

The inspection teams will verify whether coaching institutes comply with fire safety requirements, building regulations and other mandatory safety norms. The MCD will provide the agencies with details of 923 coaching centres surveyed across Delhi to facilitate coordinated action, said a statement.

Sood also directed the



Delhi Fire Service, Delhi Police, and other departments concerned to initiate action against institutions found violating prescribed safety standards or operating in contravention of applicable regulations.

The MCD has been asked to submit a daily action taken report to the minister's office on enforcement and compliance measures, according to the statement. The directions were issued during a high-level review meeting attended by officials from the Home Department, MCD, Urban Development Department, Delhi Fire Service, DDMA and the Directorate of Higher Education, it stated.

The minister also reviewed safety standards, infrastructure and the existing regulatory mechanism governing coaching institutes.

He informed that the Directorate of Higher Education is preparing a regulatory framework for coaching centres to address regulatory gaps, strengthen accountability, improve safety standards and establish a transparent oversight mechanism.

Sood asserted that student safety and welfare were the government's priority and warned that institutions found compromising safety through negligence or non-compliance would face strict action.

"The safety and welfare of students is our highest priority. Any negligence affecting student safety will not be tolerated. All coaching institutes must strictly comply with safety norms and guidelines issued by the Government and the Courts from time to time," the minister said.

Noida and Ghaziabad seal 58 establishments over fire safety lapses

OUR CORRESPONDENT

NOIDA/GHAZIABAD: A day after a devastating fire at a coaching institute in Lucknow's Aliganj area claimed 15 lives, authorities in Noida and Ghaziabad launched a large-scale crackdown on establishments allegedly flouting fire safety norms, sealing around 60 premises.

Officials said two coaching centres in Noida and 56 establishments in Ghaziabad, including coaching institutes, play schools and dispensaries, were sealed during the drive for failing to comply with mandatory fire safety requirements.

In Ghaziabad, the Ghaziabad Development Authority (GDA) carried out inspections across multiple zones and sealed establishments that failed to produce valid fire no-objection certificates (NOCs).

According to GDA officials,

a list of 206 establishments without fire NOCs has been prepared, with further action likely in the coming days.

"During the drive, 56 establishments were sealed as they failed to produce fire NOCs. We have also written to the fire department to initiate action under the applicable fire safety regulations," said Rudresh Shukla, media coordinator of the GDA.

The enforcement drive covered Raj Nagar, Raj Nagar District Centre, Rajendra Nagar, Lajpat Nagar, Satyam Enclave and Ambedkar Road.

In Noida, district authorities sealed Om Education Centre in Sector 149 after finding it was operating without registration and a fire safety certificate. Authorities said inspections would continue across NCR, with 82 cases already filed against high-rise building violators.

'Encounter is not justice, hang him': Father of 11-year-old girl

Accused cab driver shot in leg during escape attempt

OUR CORRESPONDENT

NEW DELHI: "Encounter is not justice, I want the accused to be hanged," said a grief-stricken father of an 11-year-old girl who was allegedly abducted, raped and murdered, as he watched her mortal remains being consigned to flames at a crematorium in south Delhi's Chattarpur here on Tuesday.

The father's remarks came after the Delhi Police shot the accused cab driver in the leg during an alleged escape attempt while he was in custody. Police said the accused, a native of Bihar, tried to flee during the investigation, prompting officers to open fire to prevent his escape. He was subsequently taken for medical treatment, and his condition was stated to be stable.

Recounting the horror of that morning, the victim's father said that they were sleeping on the pavement when the cab driver, whom he called a "darinda" (beast), kidnapped his daughter.

"My daughter also shouted. I ran behind the cab and even hurled a stick at his car," he said, with his voice choking with emotion.

He said that he noticed the car and he called the police. "Gave the number of the car to the police. The officer who came was very helpful. He told



KEY POINTS

» Recounting the horror of that morning, the victim's father said that they were sleeping on the pavement when the cab driver, whom he called a 'darinda' (beast), kidnapped his daughter

» 'My daughter also shouted. I ran behind the cab and even hurled a stick at his car,' he said

me 'chinta mat karo hum hain apke sath' (don't worry, we are with you)," the father added.

He said he learned that the police had encountered the accused. "But I want strict and capital punishment for him," he said, as his anguish became palpable.

The heart-wrenching scenes at the crematorium underscored the trauma of a family shattered by a crime.

The minor's body was brought to the crematorium amid heavy police deployment, with officers stationed in and around the premises to maintain law and order.

The child's family members were inconsolable. They repeatedly broke down and had to be supported by relatives as they struggled to come to terms with the loss. Several family members were seen lying on the ground, crying uncontrollably. Many relatives fainted during the cremation and were assisted by those present.

"We have lost everything. The accused must be given capital punishment," a man shouted.

The atmosphere at the crematorium was filled with cries of grief as mourners gathered around the bereaved family.

According to police, the girl was allegedly kidnapped from a pavement in Mehrauli where she was sleeping beside her family in the early hours of Monday. A cab driver allegedly abducted her, raped her and later strangled her before dumping the body and hiding her body under stones in a forested stretch along the Faridabad-Gurgaon road.

The accused was arrested within six hours of the crime after more than 20 police teams tracked him through CCTV footage and technical surveillance.

Tilak Nagar murder traced to weeks-old dispute over Rs 150

PRAJYOT DEOGHARE

NEW DELHI: A dispute over Rs 150 allegedly led to the fatal stabbing of a young man in West Delhi's Tilak Nagar area, with police apprehending three juveniles in connection with the murder.

The incident came to light after a PCR call was received at Tilak Nagar Police Station reporting that a man had been stabbed.

Police identified the victim as Paras, who sustained multiple stab wounds and later succumbed to his injuries while undergoing treatment at Deen Dayal Upadhyay Hospital.

An FIR was registered under relevant sections of the Bharatiya Nyaya Sanhita, and an investigation was launched immediately.

According to police, a woman called the PCR on June 22 and reported that her brother had been stabbed in the thigh and back and was bleeding heavily.

Responding officers rushed to the spot and found bloodstains near the scene. The injured man had already been taken to hospital, where he later died.

A special investigation team was constituted to crack the case. During the inquiry, the victim's sister told police she had found her brother lying unconscious and injured near their residence and had no information about the attackers.

Investigators examined

TAKEAWAYS

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CCTV footage from the area and simultaneously gathered local intelligence. Based on technical surveillance and field inquiries, three juveniles were identified and apprehended from a park near B-Block, Chowkhandi, in Tilak Nagar.

During questioning, the juveniles allegedly revealed that around 40 to 45 days earlier, Paras had forcibly taken Rs 150 from one of them and had refused to return the money.

On the intervening night of June 21 and 22, they confronted him over the issue. Following an initial altercation, Paras fled the spot, but the trio allegedly tracked him down, assaulted him and stabbed him multiple times.

All three juveniles were produced before the Juvenile Justice Board and sent to protective custody. Further investigation is underway.

ED raids Delhi locations in 2021 Mundra heroin case

NARESH BISWANI

NEW DELHI: The Enforcement Directorate (ED) on Tuesday conducted searches at multiple locations in Delhi as part of its money laundering investigation linked to the 3,000-kg heroin seizure at Gujarat's Mundra Port in 2021, one of the largest drug busts in the country.

Sources said the raids were carried out at five premises linked to Harpreet Singh Talwar, also known as Happy

Passia, Shamshudern and their associates. The action was undertaken by the ED headquarters under the Prevention of Money Laundering Act (PMLA) to trace assets allegedly generated through drug trafficking and uncover financial networks connected to the case. Officials said the probe is focused on allegations that proceeds from narcotics trafficking were routed through legitimate businesses, including entertainment establishments in Delhi, to conceal their



origin. Investigators are examining financial transactions, property holdings and links between the accused and various commercial entities.

Documents and financial records seized during the

searches are being scrutinised to determine whether illicit funds were laundered through seemingly lawful business operations.

Harpreet Singh Talwar, who was earlier arrested by the National Investigation Agency (NIA) in connection with the case, is currently out on bail. The ED is now concentrating on tracing the movement of funds allegedly generated from the narcotics trade.

The case stems from the seizure of nearly three metric

tonnes of heroin concealed in cargo containers at Mundra Port in Gujarat in 2021. The consignment, estimated to be worth around Rs 21,000 crore in the international market, triggered a multi-agency investigation. Officials described the latest searches as part of a broader effort to dismantle the financial infrastructure supporting international drug trafficking networks and identify individuals involved in handling or concealing proceeds from the illegal trade.

'Do not panic': DU VC advises students to fill maximum preferences on CSAS portal

NEW DELHI: Delhi University Vice Chancellor Yogesh Singh on Wednesday urged students not to panic during the undergraduate admission process. He advised students to apply for as many courses and college preferences as possible once the Common Seat Allocation System (CSAS) portal opens.

His remarks came a day after the declaration of the Common University Entrance Test (CUET-UG) 2026 results on Tuesday. Singh addressed concerns over the ongoing CBSE re-evaluation process and pending revised Class 12 marks. He said admissions depend on CUET scores, so students need not panic.

"There is no need to panic. Admissions are based entirely on CUET scores. If there is any change in Class 12 marks after re-evaluation, students can submit

the updated documents by September 30 and, if required, the deadline can be extended further into October," he said.

The vice chancellor advised aspirants to carefully read admission guidelines and opt for as many preferences as possible while filling the CSAS form.

"Many students make the mistake of choosing only four to six options. If they do not get those choices in the first round, they regret not filling more preferences," Singh said, adding that students should choose as many options as possible because they can always upgrade in subsequent rounds.

On the impact of CUET on admissions, Singh described the entrance examination as a "major reform" that has enhanced diversity in Delhi University's student population.

"Students are now coming from almost every state, district and tehsil of the country. Children from big cities, small towns and villages are getting admission through a common platform," he said.

He said CUET has helped address disparities in evaluation standards across school education boards.

"Earlier, admissions based on Class 12 marks and some boards were considered more liberal while others were stricter in awarding marks. CUET provides a common benchmark for all students, which has been implemented and has been giving us good results," he said.

Around 30 per cent of eligible students opted for the fourth year, which offers research opportunities and direct eligibility for one-year master's programmes, Singh said. PII

CAMPUS TO ACCOMMODATE UP TO 8,000 STUDENTS

New Rs 1,668 crore AUD campus to come up on 50-acre Dheerpur site: CM Rekha Gupta

OUR CORRESPONDENT

NEW DELHI: In a major expansion of Delhi's higher education infrastructure, the Rekha Gupta-led government on Wednesday approved the construction of a new campus of Dr. B.R. Ambedkar University Delhi (AUD) at Dheerpur in North Delhi at an estimated cost of Rs 1,668 crore. The project, cleared by the Expenditure Finance Committee (EFC), is expected to significantly enhance the university's capacity

and provide modern educational facilities to thousands of students. Spread across nearly 20 hectares (50 acres), the campus will be developed in phases and is ultimately designed to accommodate around 8,000 students. In the first phase, academic facilities will be created for 5,400 students, along with hostel accommodation for 840 students and residential facilities for faculty and staff.

Chief Minister Rekha Gupta said the project would help strengthen Delhi's posi-

Campus would be developed as a GRIHA 5-Star green facility: CM

tion as a leading education hub. "The new Ambedkar University campus at Dheerpur will not only enhance Delhi's higher education capacity but will also set a new benchmark for a modern, inclusive and sustainable academic environment," she said.

The new campus will feature academic blocks, a central library, administrative buildings, student activity centres, sports infrastructure and a 2,500-seat grand auditorium. The project will be implemented by the Public Works Department (PWD) following approval from the EFC meeting attended by PWD Minister Parvesh Sahib Singh, Education Minister Ashish Sood and senior officials.

Emphasising sustainability, Gupta said the campus would

be developed as a GRIHA 5-Star green facility. "The project is an outstanding example of the integration of education and sustainable development," she said.

The campus will feature solar and geothermal energy systems, rainwater harvesting and wastewater recycling. Officials said the project will provide a sustainable, future-ready learning environment and expand access to quality higher education across the capital.

Four nabbed in mule bank account racket

NEW DELHI: Delhi Police has busted a racket involved in supplying mule bank accounts and routing proceeds of cyber fraud, arresting four persons from Madhya Pradesh and Rajasthan, officials said on Wednesday. The accused have been identified as Faem Bag (26), Shubham Goyal (27), Deepak Parjapat (28) and Manoj Kumar Tailor (39).

The case surfaced after a 31-year-old woman from Wazirabad reported that Rs 1 lakh had been fraudulently transferred from her bank account on May 26. She told police that she had neither authorised the transactions

nor shared her banking credentials with anyone. During the investigation, police analysed IP records, email IDs, mobile numbers, call detail records and the money trail across multiple accounts. Technical surveillance led investigators to Ratlam in Madhya Pradesh, where the accused were traced and arrested.

Police said Deepak and Shubham allegedly convinced Faem to provide his bank account for a commission of Rs 2,000. The account details were then passed on through Manoj and allegedly used to channel cyber fraud proceeds. MPOST

INCLUDES SAFETY AND DRAINAGE WORKS

Govt clears ₹658 crore road upgrade projects

AIMAN FATIMA

NEW DELHI: In one of the biggest road infrastructure approvals this year, the Delhi government on Wednesday cleared projects worth Rs.657.99 crore to strengthen 270.63 km of roads across the city, with the work set to cover major stretches in East, North and South Delhi. The projects, approved by the Expenditure Finance Committee (EFC) chaired by Chief Minister Rekha Gupta, will be executed under a new zone-wise tendering model aimed at improving quality control, monitoring and accountability.

The government has allocated Rs.147.08 crore for 58.29 km of roads in East Delhi, Rs.247.31 crore for 104.42 km in North Delhi and Rs.263.61 crore for 107.92 km in South Delhi. Together, the works will cover more than 270 km of key arterial roads and are targeted for completion by October.

Chief Minister Rekha Gupta said, "The project will make Delhi's roads safer, more durable and of better quality. It will improve the condition of several key roads across East, North and South Delhi and help strengthen road infrastructure in line with modern standards."

Among the prominent roads included in the project are Road No. 66 from Seelampur to Gokalpuri (3.8 km),



Project monitoring will be carried out through the GSDL/DPMG portal

Outer Ring Road from Chandgi Ram Akhara to Wazirabad (2.5 km), GT Road (1.88 km) and Avtar Singh Marg (1.9 km) in East Delhi. In North Delhi, roads such as Pankha Road (2.48 km), Satguru Ram Singh Marg (3.4 km), Lala Ganesh Das Khatri Marg (1.27 km) and Major Sudesh Marg (1.9 km) will be strengthened. South Delhi will see upgrades on stretches including SSN Marg (10.5 km), Mandi Road (4 km), Barapullah Elevated Road Phase-I (4.3 km), Nelson Mandela Marg (4.04 km) and Pankha Road (4.08 km).

The project includes cold milling of damaged road surfaces, laying of Dense Bitumi-

nous Macadam (DBM) and Bituminous Concrete (BC), tack coat application, road markings, installation of signboards and safety infrastructure, and construction of kerb channels for drainage.

Highlighting a major policy change, Gupta said, "For the first time, Delhi is adopting a zone-wise composite tendering system in place of the conventional road-wise tendering model. This will help make project execution, quality control and monitoring more effective."

The Chief Minister said all contracts would carry a five-year Defect Liability Period (DLP). "If a pothole develops on any road during the liability period, it will be repaired within 48 hours," she said.

Project monitoring will be carried out through the GSDL/DPMG portal, with geo-tagged photographs uploaded before, during and after construction. Independent quality audits will be conducted by CSIR-CRRI and the School of Planning and Architecture (SPA).

Emphasising environmental safeguards, Gupta said the tenders have been prepared in accordance with CAQM norms. "Better roads will not only provide safer and smoother travel for citizens but will also help reduce dust pollution and contribute to a cleaner environment in the Capital," she said.

Work begins on Central Vista Metro Corridor

NARESH BISWANI

NEW DELHI: The Delhi Metro Rail Corporation (DMRC) on Wednesday commenced construction work at Central Secretariat Metro Station for the upcoming Central Vista Metro Corridor under Phase V(A) of the Delhi Metro network.

The project was launched in the presence of Union Minister for Housing and Urban Affairs and Power Manohar Lal, along with senior officials from the Ministry of Housing and Urban Affairs and the DMRC.

The corridor forms part of the extension of the Magenta Line from Janakpuri West to RK Ashram Marg. Once completed, Central Secretariat will become a major interchange station connecting the Magenta, Yellow and Violet lines, significantly improving connectivity across central Delhi.

The nearly 10-km underground corridor will have nine stations — Shivaji Stadium, Yuge Yugeen Bharat, Central Secretariat, Kartavya Bhawan, India Gate, War Memorial-High Court, Baroda House, Bharat Mandapam and Indraprastha.

According to the DMRC, the corridor is designed to improve access to key government offices, courts, memorials and major event venues in the Central Vista area. Officials said the project will enhance connectivity, reduce travel time and help meet the capital's growing transportation needs.

STRESSES TECH-DRIVEN CRIME PREVENTION

L-G Sandhu calls for proactive, citizen-centric policing in Delhi

SHIWANGI SHUKLA

NEW DELHI: Delhi Lieutenant Governor Sardar Tranjit Singh Sandhu on Wednesday chaired a high-level review meeting with the Commissioner of Police and senior officers at the Delhi Police Headquarters, stressing the need for proactive, humane, visible and citizen-centric policing across the national capital.

The meeting marked the Lieutenant Governor's first visit to the Police Headquarters. All Special Commissioners of Police, Joint Commissioners of Police and Dep-



uty Commissioners of Police attended the review.

Addressing senior officers, Sandhu emphasised that police personnel must remain approachable, empathetic and firm, while ensuring fairness and transparency in their conduct to strengthen public trust and confidence. He said policing should focus not only

on law enforcement but also on prevention and proactive engagement with citizens.

The Lieutenant Governor endorsed the force's commitment to maintaining strict control over crime and reiterated that the safety and security of women, children and senior citizens remain non-negotiable. He directed officers to

Capital races against monsoon: 30.91L metric tonnes silt removed, 1,900 km drains cleaned

AIMAN FATIMA

NEW DELHI: With the monsoon knocking on Delhi's doors and memories of flooded roads still fresh, the city government has launched an extensive pre-rain preparedness drive, claiming record desilting of drains and large-scale inspections across all 70 Assembly constituencies. Public Works Department (PWD) Minister Parvesh Sahib Singh on Wednesday reviewed ongoing works in Moti Nagar and said the government was focusing on prevention rather than crisis management to minimize waterlogging this season.

According to the Delhi government, the Public Works

Department has completed desilting of 1,900.15 kilometres of drains out of a total network of 2,125.87 kilometres, achieving 89.38 per cent completion ahead of the monsoon.

The Irrigation and Flood Control (I&FC) Department has meanwhile reported the removal of 30,91,242 metric tonnes of silt, significantly higher than the approximately 19 lakh metric tonnes removed last year.

Official data showed that 2,84,655 metric tonnes of silt were removed from 21 major drains, while the crucial Najafgarh Drain alone accounted for 12,77,172 metric tonnes. Combined desilting across 22 major drains reached 15,61,827



metric tonnes, while 15,29,415 metric tonnes were removed from 55 supplementary drains.

Officials said the exercise is expected to improve drainage capacity, facilitate faster discharge of rainwater and strengthen flood-prevention measures across the Capital. Reviewing the prepara-

tions, Parvesh Sahib Singh said, "Across Delhi today, our senior officers, Chief Engineers and field teams are inspecting roads and drains before the monsoon. We have running maintenance contracts, but the reality of the work can only be checked on the ground."

He added that officers had been deployed across different constituencies and that inspections would continue over the coming days. "In the next 10 to 15 days, all 70 Assembly constituencies of Delhi will be inspected," the minister said.

Stressing accountability, Singh said the government's focus was to ensure residents do not face the annual problem of waterlogging. "Our objec-

tive is clear, Delhi's citizens should not face waterlogging during the rains. Every drain, every road and every vulnerable point is being reviewed. Wherever shortcomings are found, immediate corrective action will be taken," he said.

The minister further said the government was prioritising continuous monitoring, field-level supervision and coordination between departments. The citywide inspections and record desilting figures, officials said, are aimed at ensuring smoother traffic movement, better drainage efficiency and a more resilient response to heavy rainfall during the upcoming monsoon season.

MCD streamlines trade licence process with portal integration

OUR CORRESPONDENT

NEW DELHI: In a major step towards promoting Ease of Doing Business and strengthening citizen-centric digital governance, the Municipal Corporation of Delhi (MCD) has integrated the General Trade Licence (GTL) facility with its Property Tax Portal with effect from 23 June 2026.

With this integration, traders and business establishments will no longer need to access a separate portal for obtaining a new General Trade Licence or renewing an existing one. The earlier GTL portal has now been discontinued for all fresh



licence and renewal-related services.

Under the revised mechanism, the General Trade Licence fee will be automatically calculated at 15 per cent of the applicable Property Tax. Once the prescribed amount is paid through the Property

Tax Portal, the online payment receipt generated by the system will itself serve as the valid General Trade Licence.

The initiative is aimed at simplifying regulatory procedures, reducing compliance requirements, and making services more accessible and efficient for Delhi's business community.

MCD remains committed to enhancing transparency, improving digital service delivery, and creating a more business-friendly environment in the national capital while encouraging continued feedback and cooperation from citizens and stakeholders.

Delhi intensifies anti-dengue drive ahead of monsoon

NEW DELHI: With the monsoon season approaching and mosquito-borne diseases expected to rise, the Delhi government on Wednesday reviewed its preparedness against dengue, malaria and chikungunya, directing all departments to intensify surveillance, vector-control measures and public awareness campaigns across the capital.

Chairing a high-level review meeting, Health Minister Dr. Pankaj Kumar Singh said the government had

strengthened its disease-monitoring and response systems to prevent outbreaks during the rainy season.

According to official data, Delhi has reported 347 dengue cases, 87 malaria cases and 19 chikungunya cases till June 20, 2026. No deaths due to dengue or malaria have been reported so far this year.

"The Delhi Government is fully prepared to tackle Dengue and other Vector-Borne Diseases. We have strengthened surveillance, hospital pre-

paredness, diagnostic facilities and vector-control measures across the city," Dr. Singh said. He added, "The fight against Dengue cannot be won by government efforts alone. Public participation is essential."

The minister informed that a network of 35 Sentinel Sur-

veillance Hospitals is actively monitoring cases, while all government and private hospitals and laboratories have been directed to report infections in real time through the Integrated Health Information Platform (IHIP). A control room has also been set up at the Directorate General of Health Services (DGHS) headquarters for continuous monitoring and coordination.

Highlighting preventive efforts by civic agencies, officials said that till June 20,

over 1.81 crore household and premises inspections had been conducted to identify mosquito breeding sites. Additionally, more than 1.97 lakh houses were sprayed, around 38,500 notices issued, and over 4,200 enforcement actions initiated against violations linked to mosquito breeding.

Dr. Singh directed hospitals to remain mosquito-free and urged residents to prevent water stagnation, observe weekly dry days and use repellents.

MPOST

Delhi govt identifies 169 waterlogging hotspots

9 underpasses flagged

OUR CORRESPONDENT

NEW DELHI: Ahead of the monsoon season, the Delhi government has identified 169 locations across the capital that are prone to waterlogging, including 31 hotspots along the Ring Road, according to the recently issued flood control order.

The order noted that persistent waterlogging was reported at these locations in 2025. Nine underpasses, including Minto Bridge, Zakhira, Dwarka, Moolchand and Pul Prahlad Pur, have been flagged as particularly vulnerable. Authorities said temporary pump sets have been installed and standard operating procedures put in place to manage water accumulation.

In addition, 445 waterlogging hotspots mapped using traffic police data from 2023, 2024 and 2025 are under close monitoring.

Key vulnerable areas include the ITO crossing, Delhi Secretariat, Indira Gandhi Indoor Stadium, Rajghat, Bahadur Shah Zafar Marg and the Pragati Maidan tunnel approach roads.

The flood control order also outlines measures to tackle potential flooding from the Yamuna. Sixteen flood control posts have been established across the city, while 11 regulator drains will be operated to manage water discharge into the river and prevent backflow during high flood conditions.

Authorities have also identified 14 villages in the Alipur, Wazirabad and Shahdara areas as vulnerable to flooding during periods of high water levels in the Yamuna.

Okhla landfill set for complete disposal by December: Mayor

ANAMTA FATIMA

NEW DELHI: Delhi Mayor Pravesh Wahi on Wednesday reviewed the ongoing bio-remediation and waste management operations at the Okhla landfill site and said that the Municipal Corporation of Delhi (MCD) was moving steadily towards eliminating the landfill within the stipulated timeline.

During his visit, MCD officials briefed the Mayor on the status of bio-mining activities and measures being undertaken to process accumulated waste at the site. Senior officials, including MCD Commissioner Sanjeev Khirwar, Additional Commissioner Dr. Satendra Singh Dursawat and Engineer-in-Chief P.C. Meena, were present during the inspection. Expressing satisfaction with the progress achieved so far, Wahi said that nearly



23 acres of land at the Okhla landfill site have already been cleared of waste, marking a significant milestone in the city's landfill remediation efforts.

The Mayor stated that disposal of legacy waste accumulated over the years is expected to be completed within approximately one week. He added that fresh waste reaching the site would continue to be processed systematically, with the objective of ensuring complete

disposal by December 2026.

Wahi also noted that Delhi Chief Minister Rekha Gupta is personally monitoring bio-mining operations across landfill sites in the Capital. He said that MCD personnel and machinery were working continuously to ensure timely completion of the project and fulfil the broader objective of making Delhi cleaner and reducing environmental burden caused by landfill waste.



Yogi Adityanath
Chief Minister, Uttar Pradesh



Nand Gopal Gupta 'Nandi'
Minister of Industrial Development
Uttar Pradesh



Jaswant Saini
Minister of State for Industrial Development
Uttar Pradesh

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BRIEFLY CROSSED INTO PAKISTANI AIRSPACE NEAR AMRITSAR

DGCA acts after Air India flight strays into Pakistan airspace

NARESH BISWANI

NEW DELHI: The Directorate General of Civil Aviation (DGCA) has initiated interim action against an Air Traffic Controller (ATC) at Amritsar and the operating crew of an Air India flight after an aircraft briefly entered Pakistani airspace during its approach to Amritsar Airport on June 22.

Oversight authorities are now reviewing operational decisions made during that phase. One outcome has been the suspension of certain responsibilities pending further review. While such incidents remain rare, they prompt scrutiny of navigation protocols near borders. At present, investigations continue without public updates.

The DGCA stated, Air India flight AI-479, flown using an Airbus A321 marked VT-PPV along the Delhi to Amritsar path, received directions to



DGCA has launched a probe into the matter

REPRESENTATIONAL IMAGE

circle due to ongoing checks after birds hit the runway. As the plane began descending, deviation into Pakistan's sky occurred momentarily under guidance from radar signals.

The aviation regulator stated that coordination occurred with Pakistani air traffic control bodies during the event, safety being maintained throughout. Follow-

ing this, the plane gave up its approach, turned toward Delhi instead, arriving without complications after a redirected flight path. The DGCA noted that temporary measures were applied to both the Amritsar air traffic controller involved and the flight personnel, due to their failure to notify the event via official procedures.

Close to the India-Paki-

Highlights

» Oversight authorities are now reviewing operational decisions made during that phase. One outcome has been the suspension of certain responsibilities pending further review

» Close to the India-Pakistan frontier, the event gained notice. Surveillance of air traffic across northern regions persists, shaped by ongoing alertness to potential threats

stan frontier, the event gained notice. Surveillance of air traffic across northern regions persists, shaped by ongoing alertness to potential threats.

Occasionally, flights near borders drift into neighboring skies while circling or being guided by radar - when coordination exists with appropriate control agencies.

Not uncommon is this shift during routine maneuvering, so long as communication channels remain active between operators and oversight bodies. Though proxim-

ity may increase complexity, alignment through procedural exchange tends to prevent disputes.

An investigation by the DGCA appears into what caused the aircraft to stray beyond its assigned airspace along with the failure to report it promptly. Despite this, authorities confirm there was never a risk to those on board because air traffic control maintained oversight during the entire episode.

Further investigation of the issue continues.

Fight over keeping doors open turns fatal on Mumbai local

Police arrest accused after altercation amid heavy rains

OUR CORRESPONDENT

MUMBAI: A 22-year-old man was allegedly stabbed to death by a co-passenger on a Mumbai local train during an argument over whether the doors should be kept open amid the rains, in the second such incident this year, officials said on Wednesday.

The accused, subsequently identified as Sachin Ramesh Suvarna (30), was arrested hours later following a massive manhunt, which included the scanning of footage from nearly 400 CCTV cameras, an official said.

Victim Mayank Lohar was fatally assaulted by Suvarna inside a first-class compartment on Tuesday, which also marked the arrival of monsoon in the city, between Andheri and Borivali railway stations in the western suburbs, he said.

Officials said Lohar and Suvarna got into an altercation as the train, a Churchgate-Nalasopara fast local, pulled into the Andheri station at 10.42

The accused, subsequently identified as Sachin Ramesh Suvarna (30), was arrested hours later following a massive manhunt

pm.

One of them wanted the doors to be kept open, while the other objected, citing the rains. During the argument, Suvarna, who works at the Sahar Cargo complex of the Mumbai airport, pulled out "sattu" (a sharp weapon) from his possession and allegedly stabbed Lohar in the abdomen and chest, he said.

Lohar suffered grievous injuries and collapsed, while Suvarna, a resident of Mira Road, jumped out of the train at Borivali station before it came to a halt and ran away.

The youth was rushed to a nearby medical facility with the

help of Government Railway Police (GRP) and personnel from the Railway Protection Force (RPF), the official said. He was then taken to a civic-run hospital, where doctors declared him dead.

Sharing more details, the Western Railway administration said the train reached Borivali station at 11.04 pm, and GRP and RPF personnel reached the coach within three minutes and mobilised medical staff, along with a stretcher and porters.

The victim was brought to the emergency medical room at the station at 11.22 pm, where he was examined by a doctor.

Acting on medical advice, railway authorities coordinated his transfer to Shatabdi Hospital in Kandivali by an ambulance at 11.42 pm, with GRP and RPF personnel accompanying him during transit, an official said. The railway administration also secured CCTV footage and other evidence and handed them over to the investigating agencies.

From Page 1

Deal first

the nuclear material facilities will be supervised by the IAEA -- in all letters," he said. Those inspections are key for the deal, which calls for Iran's stockpile of uranium to be "down-blended" from highly enriched levels.

There was no immediate reaction from Iran. On Tuesday, Iran's Foreign Ministry spokesperson Esmail Baghaei told reporters in Tehran that UN inspectors were not scheduled to examine nuclear sites bombed by the US last year, rejecting comments made a day before by US Vice President JD Vance.

The IAEA has been allowed to visit other nuclear sites in Iran since the 12-day war in 2025, such as the Bushehr nuclear power plant. But without accessing the enrichment sites, the IAEA says it is unable to verify the status of Iran's stockpile or check the cascades of centrifuges used to enrich uranium.

The US and Iran agreed to a deal last week that calls for Tehran to dilute its stockpile of enriched uranium and waives US-backed sanctions on Iranian oil, while giving each side 60 days to hammer out broader agreements.

Meanwhile, US Secretary of State Marco Rubio arrived in the Persian Gulf for a three-nation tour, beginning with a closed-door meeting and private working lunch in Abu Dhabi with Emirati President Mohamed bin Zayed Al Nahyan, the State Department said Wednesday.

Rubio is scheduled to travel next to Kuwait and then Bahrain for meetings with their leaders later Wednesday and Thursday.

An Iranian diplomat rejected comments on Wednesday by the head of the IAEA, saying nuclear site inspections would only be possible after a final US-Iran deal.

Kazem Gharibabadi, a deputy foreign minister, made the comment on X. He was reacting to remarks earlier in the day by Rafael Mariano Grossi in Japan. "No meeting was held with Grossi in Switzerland, despite his request. Nor is there any plan for access to the facilities that were attacked or to nuclear material," Gharibabadi wrote.

In a Dubai datelined report, PTI said that India has advised its people to continue avoiding all non-essential travel to Iran until further notice, despite recent improvements in the security situation.

The Indian Embassy in Tehran said it has been closely monitoring the prevailing security situation in Iran and was issuing a revised advisory in light of recent positive developments and improvements in the overall situation.

"Notwithstanding the recent improvements, Indian nationals are advised to continue to avoid all non-essential travel to Iran until further notice," the mission said in its advisory - a copy of which was posted on social

media.

The mission further advised Indian citizens presently residing in Iran, as well as those who may be required to travel to the country for unavoidable reasons, to exercise a high degree of caution, remain vigilant at all times and maintain constant awareness.

It urged them to closely follow local developments through credible sources of information and comply with instructions issued by local authorities.

The embassy also reiterated its advice to all Indian nationals currently in Iran, as well as those arriving in the country, to register their particulars with the mission at the earliest opportunity.

India-US trade pact

are moving forward in technology.

Greer added that President Donald Trump and Prime Minister Narendra Modi have an "amazing" relationship that they have nurtured over many years.

The two countries aim to salvage and recalibrate the proposed agreement after changes in the US tariff policy upended a framework deal finalised earlier this year.

Securing preferential tariff treatment in the pact has become a central objective for New Delhi after changes in the US tariff landscape eroded an advantage India had expected to enjoy over regional competitors such as Vietnam and other ASEAN economies.

WITH AGENCY INPUTS

Lucknow fire

the examinations told PTI on condition of anonymity.

Based on the findings, doctors concluded that all 15 victims died due to asphyxiation caused by smoke inhalation.

The post-mortem findings of severe smoke inhalation matched survivors' accounts of the choking conditions inside the burning building.

"Smoke was everywhere," 32-year-old Mohd Asif, a survivor of the Aliganj inferno, told PTI on Tuesday.

"When we moved towards the staircase, we saw thick smoke coming from there. We then moved towards the front side, but smoke was coming from there too," he had said.

The observations of the post-mortem report have been shared with investigating authorities.

Explaining the findings of the autopsies, the doctor said fires in enclosed spaces often turn deadly because of smoke and toxic gases rather than direct exposure to flames.

"In enclosed spaces affected by fire, oxygen levels can rapidly decline while toxic gases accumulate, creating conditions that can lead to suffocation," the doctor said.

"In many cases, trapped occupants do not get sufficient time or opportunity to escape. The deceased must have lost consciousness due to heavy smoke before their deaths," the doctor told PTI.

UP Urban Development and Energy Minister A K Sharma

had said on Monday that preliminary information suggested the fire may have started in the building's AC duct, and the smoke led to suffocation due to the absence of a proper exit route.

Senior doctors noted that fatalities in fire incidents are frequently caused by toxic gases present in smoke. When smoke engulfs a confined space, oxygen levels drop sharply, making breathing increasingly difficult.

The burning of plastic, foam and other synthetic materials can release poisonous gases such as carbon monoxide, which interferes with the body's ability to carry oxygen in the blood and can cause unconsciousness and death within a short period, they said.

A devastating fire ripped through a three-storey commercial complex, which housed an animation centre and a pet shop, Aliganj's Usha Mehta Marg on Monday afternoon, killing 15 people, most of them students, and injuring several others.

The tragedy triggered widespread outrage and prompted the Uttar Pradesh government to order a high-level probe into the incident.

A two-member Special Investigation Team (SIT) has been set up to probe the cause of the fire and possible lapses. The SIT visited the incident site on Tuesday.

While the site of one of Lucknow's deadliest fire tragedies in recent years remains cordoned off with yellow police tape, the Lucknow Development Authority (LDA) on Wednesday pasted a notice on the building over alleged violation of building bylaws and unauthorised use of the premises, which had been approved for residential purposes.

After the statutory period expires, the building could be demolished, officials said.

Meanwhile, the police have registered a case against the building owner and other persons associated with establishments operating from the premises.

So far, four people -- building owner Virendra Prasad Shukla, gaming institute director Tushank Krishna Jaiswal, IT professional Suresh Kumar Sahu and pet shop owner Ram Krishna Upadhyay -- have been arrested.

The state government has also announced compensation for the families of the victims and directed officials to inspect for the principal amount due of USD 4,105,189.34," he said.

Nirav faces \$1m bill

That was a valid demand for a liability to the Bank under the Personal Guarantee," Justice Tinkler ruled.

"The Personal Guarantee is not, as a matter of Indian law, void/unenforceable. Mr Modi is therefore liable under the Personal Guarantee to the Bank for the principal amount due of USD 4,105,189.34," he said.

The judge also pointed to "the interest on that sum for which Mr Modi is liable", which

adds up to an estimated USD 11.5 million until March 2026, with further interest accruing following that date.

"The interest calculated on the basis set out by the bank is to be added to the principal sum in calculating the total amount due," the judge concluded.

Bank of India, represented by Milan Kapadia of Fladgate LLP, had been pursuing the case since 2018 when allegations began to circulate regarding companies associated with Modi.

"This case is a commercial banking recovery claim by Bank of India against Mr Modi as guarantor. It does not concern, and makes no findings in respect of, the wider fraud allegations against Mr Modi or the Punjab National Bank fraud," Fladgate clarified, following this week's judgment.

There were three main issues before the judge to determine: whether Modi had been validly served with a demand; whether that demand related to a liability he owed to the bank; and whether the personal guarantee was enforceable.

On all fronts, Justice Tinkler found in favour of Bank of India after the court also heard from Indian law experts in a case Modi had largely chosen to represent himself as a "Litigant in Person".

At several hearings over the past year, he sought adjournments on the grounds of suffering from severe vision loss, clinical depression and prison constraints.

The judgment records "significant disruption" caused when Modi was moved from HMP Thameside in south London to HMP Pentonville in the north of the city last October, without arrangements being made to transfer his case papers. The prison authorities at Pentonville also failed on two occasions to produce Modi to court despite valid court orders.

Taratala warehouse

launched rescue efforts as cries for help emerged from beneath the debris.

As the scale of the disaster became apparent, teams from the NDRF, SDRF, Kolkata Police, Kolkata Municipal Corporation and Fire Services joined the operation. The Army was called in around 2.30 pm and a full-scale rescue operation began by 3.15 pm. Four columns of the Eastern Command, including specialist engineers and medical personnel, were deployed, while sniffer dogs were brought in to locate survivors.

Chief Minister Suvenhu Adhikari visited the site, joining Urban Development Minister Agnimitra Paul, Health Minister Sharadwat Mukherjee, Fire Minister Kaushik Chowdhury, Behala West MLA and Sports Minister (Independent Charge) Indranil Khan, South 24 Parganas District Magistrate, KMC Administrator Smita Pandey and other officials. Adhikari said rescue operations were being carried out in coordination among all agencies.

According to the Chief Minister, Army and NDRF personnel had established contact

with 12 to 15 persons trapped beneath the debris. Water and oxygen were being supplied to them. He said the prompt response by Civil Defence personnel, firefighters and local residents had prevented the death toll from rising further. Twenty ambulances were deployed and Kolkata Police created a green corridor for the movement of the injured.

Adhikari later visited the trauma care centre at SSKM Hospital in the evening. Health Minister Mukherjee and the Health Secretary also monitored treatment arrangements. By evening, five deaths had been confirmed by Adhikari, while two persons remained in critical condition. Rescue operations would continue through the night, he said, adding that authorities were yet to ascertain the total number of workers trapped at the time of the collapse.

Authorities identified two of the deceased as Rohit Chowdhari (40) and Krishna Chowdhury (30). The identity of a third deceased male, aged around 30 years, was yet to be established. Among those injured and undergoing treatment were Durbasha Mallan (56), Mani Chand Kumar (22), Sahid Kumar (26), Rajesh Ruidas (25), Biswa Prakash (28), Bodan Munda (28), Rajendra Rao (55) and Ram Prasad Choudhury (21).

The chief minister said preliminary findings suggested the collapse was not caused by rainfall or loose soil conditions. He said the building plan had received Kolkata Municipal Corporation sanction on January 17, 2026. According to Adhikari, an initial assessment by KMC engineers indicated possible flaws in the approved plan, though a detailed report was awaited. The report was expected later in the night and decisions on accountability and compensation would be announced in the Assembly by him on Thursday.

He further directed the KMC Commissioner and the Urban Development Department to begin a comprehensive review of under-construction projects.

In a major policy decision, the Chief Minister ordered an immediate halt till July 31 on construction work at under-construction commercial buildings and projects in KMC area allegedly built on filled-up water-bodies whose plans had been sanctioned during the previous regime. A joint audit by officials from the PWD, Civil Defence, Fire Services and KMC will verify site and building plans. Construction may resume from August 1 only after clearance, while emergency works have been exempted. Later, KMC too issued a notification to that effect.

Meanwhile, SMPA clarified that it had granted a 30-year lease from August 1, 2024, to M/s Behera Brothers for about 6,689 square metres of land to establish a warehouse and cold storage facility. The port authority said obtaining all statutory approvals and clearances before construction was the responsibility of the lessee.

Police have begun a criminal investigation into the collapse. Sources said an FIR was being drafted on Wednesday night. Three persons have

been detained for questioning, though no arrests had been made till late in the evening.

Late in the evening, the Chief Secretary and Home Secretary reached the site to monitor the rescue operation, which continued under floodlights amid hopes that more survivors could still be pulled out from beneath the wreckage.

CRPF DIG suspended

They said the charges involve sharing audio-visual and pictorial content on social media platforms that allegedly called for "changing" the country's lawfully elected government during the passage of the Central Armed Police Forces (General Administration) Bill 2026.

The Bill is now an Act after it received presidential assent in April.

CRPF Director General (DG) G P Singh confirmed the development to PTI.

"All serving and uniformed officers of the CRPF are bound by the rules and statutes and the oath taken.

"Any word(s)- written or spoken or action contravening the same would be dealt appropriately in consonance with the law of the land," the DG said.

Patra could not be contacted for comment.

However, officers privy to the case said the action against the DIG was "mala fide" and "unjustified".

They said the officer (Patra) is being targeted because he was the lead petitioner among the CAPF cadre officers who fought cases related to their promotions and service parity with the IPS up to the Supreme Court.

"The DIG is being unfairly treated and punished by the CRPF headquarters because he led the legal battle for the rightful claims of the cadre officers on par with the Indian Police Service (IPS) officers who join the CAPFs on deputation," a senior officer said on the condition of anonymity.

He claimed that about two dozen other officers of the force who prominently fought court cases were recently issued "hasty" posting orders.

An association of ex-CAPF officers has also called a press conference on July 2 against the "hasty and illegal" suspension of the DIG, in addition to targeting CAPF personnel whose families protested the CAPF Bill at the Rajghat in the national capital in April.

"DIG Patra is an outstanding officer who has been commended with multiple awards," said Ranbir Singh, general secretary of the Alliance of All Ex Paramilitary Forces Welfare Association (AAPWA) said.

In their representations sent to the Ministry of Home Affairs (MHA), serving cadre officers stated that the Bill's provisions were "oppressive" and "discriminatory" and that they would continue to stagnate in their current ranks if IPS deputations were not curtailed as directed by the Supreme Court in an order issued last year.

The Centre filed an appeal against this order which the apex court rejected.

The government said the bill seeks to create a unified legal framework governing the service conditions of personnel across the CAPFs, replacing the current patchwork of separate service rule regimes for cadre officers and those coming on deputation from the Indian Police Service (IPS).

MHA officers have said that the deputation of IPS officers in CAPFs was a "valid requirement" as they are an all-India service and play supervisory role in the state police organisations too.

WITH AGENCY INPUTS

MEA

are abroad, the officials said. "A passport is issued after a lot of due diligence, and it is based on documents from several government agencies," an official said.

Senate okays

did so Tuesday — Republicans Lisa Murkowski of Alaska, Susan Collins of Maine, Rand Paul of Kentucky and Bill Cassidy of Louisiana. One Democrat, Sen John Fetterman of Pennsylvania, voted against.

Trump bashed the four Republicans as losers, saying, "These senators have made my job more difficult."

On this vote, the absence of two Republicans, including Sen Mitch McConnell of Kentucky, who was admitted to the hospital recently for an undisclosed matter, left the GOP without a full majority to halt the effort. Sen Dave McCormick also missed the vote.

The vote comes as the Pentagon is seeking USD 80 billion from Congress mostly for the Iran war as it backfills munitions and stockpiles.

The president is not pleased with the Republicans who have been critical of the deal he struck with Iran, according to one GOP senator granted anonymity to discuss the private dynamics.

The terms of the Iran deal are spelled out in a memorandum of understanding that Trump signed last week, starting a 60-day clock for the sides to reach a broader agreement over ending Iran's nuclear programme.

But Republicans have particularly objected to the \$300 billion fund to help Iran rebuild, which is far greater than the USD 1.7 billion then-President Barack Obama refunded the country under his administration's 2015 Iran deal.

Over and again, Democrats have been forcing votes on the Iran war, almost since the US and Israel launched missile strikes on Iran on Feb 28.

The Pentagon early on had estimated the war cost USD 11.3 billion during its first week, and senators said experts put the overall price tag of Operation Epic Fury higher, at some USD 100 billion.

The Trump administration is seeking USD 1.5 trillion in defense funding this year — a nearly 50% increase — including USD 350 billion that it wants in a so-called budget reconciliation package.

'WE NEED DOCTORS IN THIS COUNTRY'

SC declines to intervene in pvt medical college fee row

MPOST BUREAU

NEW DELHI: “We need doctors in this country,” the Supreme Court said on Wednesday while refusing to entertain a petition which alleged that the fee structure in private medical colleges in Rajasthan was exorbitant.

A bench of Justices B V Nagarathna and Joymalya Bagchi was hearing a plea challenging an order of the Rajasthan High Court. The High Court had dismissed a petition filed by a medical aspirant who alleged that tuition fee in private medical colleges in Rajasthan ranges between Rs 18.90 lakh and Rs 25 lakh per annum and it was wholly incompatible with the income ceiling of Rs 8 lakh for the EWS eligibility.

During the hearing, the apex court said one cannot say that self-financing institutions should charge the same fee as charged by the government institutions.

HIGHLIGHTS

» A bench of Justices B V Nagarathna and Joymalya Bagchi was hearing a plea challenging an order of the Rajasthan High Court

» The HC had dismissed a petition filed by a medical aspirant who alleged that tuition fee in private medical colleges in Rajasthan ranges between Rs 18.90 lakh and Rs 25 lakh per annum and it was wholly incompatible with the income ceiling of Rs 8 lakh for the EWS eligibility

» During the hearing, the apex court said one cannot say that self-financing institutions should charge the same fee as



charged by the government institutions

» The bench observed that one has the option to avail scholarship

The bench observed, “One person cannot say that it is exorbitant in private institutions and make it on par with government institutions.”

The counsel appearing for the petitioner referred to the fee structure in Rajasthan and said it goes up to Rs 25 lakh.

The bench observed that one has the option to avail

scholarship.

“We need doctors in this country,” it said.

“We don’t find any reason to interfere with the impugned order passed by the high court. The special leave petition is dismissed. Question of law, if any, is kept open,” the bench said.

The petitioner had contended before the high court

that the fee regulatory committee was duty-bound to frame a fee structure that was rational, equitable and commensurate with the financial constraints of the EWS candidates.

The plea said the petitioner had appeared in the National Eligibility-cum-Entrance Test (Undergraduate)-2025 under the EWS category.

Flash floods leave 1 dead in Arunachal Pradesh

ITANAGAR: Incessant rain triggered flash floods in Arunachal Pradesh’s Keyi Panyor district on Wednesday, leaving one dead and four others missing, injuring 17 others and damaging at least 18 residential units, while landslides disrupted road connectivity and stranded travellers, officials said.

The body of Nirmala Gupta (35), a teacher at Vivekananda Kendra Vidyalaya (VKV) on NEEPCO campus at Yazali, was found during search and rescue operations following the devastating flash floods, Keyi Panyor Superintendent of Police Angad Mehta said.

The search and rescue operations were suspended for the day, and would resume at the break of dawn on Thursday, Mehta said. Gupta was among the five persons who went missing from NEEPCO project colony near Poosa under Yazali circle.

The remaining missing persons were identified as Elesh Marak (13), Balari Marak (30), Tao Anjina (46) and Sourav Kumar, State Disaster Management secretary Dani

Punjab CM announces five-fold hike in sarpanches’ honorarium

CHANDIGARH: Punjab Chief Minister Bhagwant Mann on Wednesday announced that the monthly honorarium of village sarpanches will be increased from Rs 2,000 to Rs 10,000 from August 15, saying they deserve respect and recognition for their contribution to rural development.

Addressing a Sarpanch Milni programme in Bathinda, Mann said panchayats are the foundation of democracy and sarpanches work day and night for the welfare of their villages.

He said the enhanced honorarium would help them support their families while motivating them to work with greater commitment for village

The monthly honorarium of village sarpanches will be increased to Rs 10,000 from August 15

development.

The chief minister said previous governments had failed to fulfil promises made to sarpanches, but his government had ensured payment of an honorarium and was now increasing it five-fold.

Emphasising the importance of rural development, Mann said the progress of vil-

lages is essential for the progress of Punjab.

He assured sarpanches that there would be no shortage of funds for development works and urged them to ensure transparent utilisation of public money.

He said Panchayati Raj Institutions play a key role in implementing government welfare and development schemes at the grassroots level.

While policies are framed by the government, sarpanches and panches ensure their effective execution, he added.

Mann called upon sarpanches to work above groupism and treat all villagers equally.

Choose path of development: Haryana CM to people of Punjab

MUKTSAR: Haryana Chief Minister Nayab Singh Saini on Wednesday appealed to the people of Punjab, where elections are due in 2027, to choose a path of development and good governance for the prosperity of the state.

Addressing a gathering here, Saini said Punjab could once again become a leading state in the country by reclaiming its legacy of progress and prosperity.

Saini targeted both the Congress and the Aam Aadmi Party (AAP) and alleged that these parties had failed to fulfil the expectations of the people.

He accused the Congress of corruption and dynastic politics, while claiming that AAP



Haryana CM Nayab Singh Saini being felicitated with a memento during a programme organised at Muktsar, Punjab

had failed to deliver on several promises made before the 2022 assembly elections in the state.

He said the AAP govern-

ment had not fulfilled its promise of providing Rs 1,100 per month to women.

In contrast, he said the Haryana government had started providing Rs 2,100 per month to eligible women from poor families under the Deendayal Lado Lakshmi Yojana.

Saini also raised concerns over drug abuse, crime, illegal mining and law and order in Punjab.

He alleged that drug trafficking, gang wars, extortion and rising crime had created an atmosphere of fear among the people.

He said many youths were struggling to find employment and were being forced to seek opportunities abroad.

'TIMELY ACTION NEEDED IN CYBER FRAUD CASES'

PM Modi expresses concern over ‘rising’ misuse of digital platforms

MPOST BUREAU

NEW DELHI: Prime Minister Narendra Modi on Wednesday expressed concern over the rising misuse of digital platforms to defraud people and stressed that such matters require coordinated, sensitive and time-bound handling by all concerned agencies.

Modi made the remarks while reviewing grievances related to cyber crime and digital arrest frauds.

He also reviewed four critical infrastructure projects across the road, power, industrial corridor and metro rail sectors, covering four states and costing around Rs 30,000 crore, an official statement said.

The reviews were done by the prime minister at the 52nd meeting of PRAGATI, the ICT-enabled, multi-modal platform aimed at fostering Pro-Active Governance and Timely Implementation by seamlessly integrating efforts of the central and state governments.

Reviewing the cases related to cyber crime and digital arrest,



REPRESENTATIVE PIC

Modi noted that citizens should not be made to run from one department or agency to another and emphasised the need for clear ownership, faster response, better coordination among law enforcement agencies, banks and digital platforms, and stronger public awareness campaigns.

He observed that in cases involving cyber fraud, timely action is crucial to prevent financial loss and restore public confidence.

The prime minister asked all stakeholders to work in close coordination to strengthen prevention, reporting, investigation and grievance redressal

mechanisms.

Modi emphasised that states should work towards enabling e-Zero FIR mechanisms for faster registration and response in cyber fraud cases.

According to the statement, the infrastructure projects, important for economic growth, regional connectivity, industrial development and public welfare, were reviewed with focus on timelines, inter-agency coordination, issue resolution and timely completion.

Modi underlined that delays in infrastructure projects not only lead to cost escalation, but also deprive people and indus-

Season’s first rains disrupt road, rail traffic in Mumbai

Several parts of city receive over 300 mm of rainfall in 24 hours

MPOST BUREAU

MUMBAI: The season’s first major spell of monsoon rain brought Mumbai to a standstill on Wednesday, inundating low-lying areas, disrupting suburban rail services and causing severe traffic congestion during peak morning hours.

According to civic officials, several parts of the city received more than 300 mm of rainfall in the 24 hours ending at 8 am. The India Meteorological Department (IMD) issued an orange alert for Mumbai, Thane and Palghar districts, forecasting heavy to very heavy rainfall accompanied by thunderstorms over the next 24 hours. The Colaba observatory in south Mumbai recorded 248 mm rainfall, while the Santacruz observatory logged 225 mm during the period. Malvani in the western suburbs received 340 mm rainfall and Parel in central Mumbai recorded 334 mm.

Heavy overnight rain led to waterlogging in several low-lying areas, including



Commuters waded through a waterlogged road in Mumbai, Wednesday PTI

Hindmata, King’s Circle and the Andheri subway, affecting vehicular movement and causing traffic snarls. Suburban train services were also impacted as rainwater accumulated on tracks at several locations. Commuters reported delays and overcrowding on local trains, particularly on Central Railway routes. Services on the Trans-Harbour line between Thane and Vashi/Panvel were disrupted after a track cave-in between Turbhe and Koparkhairane stations.

Central Railway officials said the up line on the Thane-Vashi section was declared

unsafe at 5.06 am and restored at 7.27 am with a speed restriction of 10 kmph. The down line resumed operations at 7.35 am with trains allowed to run at 30 kmph. Officials attributed the cave-in to excessive water flow.

The heavy rain also caused diversions on more than 24 BEST bus routes.

Meanwhile, a civic supervisor fell into an open drain while accompanying Mayor Ritu Tawde during an inspection of waterlogged Gandhi Market in King’s Circle. He was rescued immediately and a video of the incident went viral on social media.



Debris scattered across an area after a landslide and flash floods in Keyi Panyor PTI

Sulu said.

Of the 17 injured, three were in a critical condition and were evacuated to Ziro in Lower Subansiri district for treatment, Sulu said.

An under-construction retaining wall collapsed due to the heavy downpour, leading to waterlogging in low-lying residential areas in and around the colony, he said, adding at least 18 residential units were damaged in the incident.

UP govt cracks down on coaching centres

Allen, Paramount among institutes sealed after Lucknow tragedy

MPOST BUREAU

LUCKNOW: Uttar Pradesh authorities intensified their crackdown on coaching institutes on Wednesday, sealing several prominent coaching centres and libraries across Lucknow days after a fire in an illegally operating building claimed 15 lives.

Acting on the directions of Chief Minister Yogi Adityanath, who said no coaching centre or nursing home would be allowed to operate from a basement, joint teams of the Lucknow Development Authority (LDA) and Fire Department conducted inspections across the city. The drive is part of a statewide campaign



launched after the deadly fire exposed widespread violations of safety and building regulations. Twelve coaching institutes and libraries were sealed during the operation. Among those shut down were branches of Allen in Krishna Nagar

and Hazratganj, Gravity in Kapoorthala, and major competitive examination coaching institutes Government Exam Wala and Paramount. Officials said the institutions were found violating fire safety norms, building regulations or

operational guidelines.

The state government has ordered inspections of coaching institutes across all districts. Teams comprising officials from the police, district administration, fire department, development authorities and electrical safety departments have been tasked with checking fire NOCs, emergency exits, electrical systems, occupancy limits and compliance with approved building plans.

“No coaching centre or nursing home will be allowed to operate in a basement. Human life is precious and there can be no compromise on safety standards,” Chief Minister Yogi Adityanath said while reviewing the enforcement drive.

'GUARDED BY PIT BULLS, FED CATTLE FEED ROTIS'

UP: 13 workers held captive at factory

BISWAJEET BANERJEE

MUZAFFARNAGAR: For nearly a year, the gates of a disposable bowl and plate manufacturing unit in Uttar Pradesh’s Muzaffarnagar district became a prison for 13 labourers, allegedly held captive, assaulted and forced to work without wages.

Among those rescued during a police raid this week were two minors aged 16 and 17. The workers, who had been lured from railway stations and bus stands with promises of employment, regular salaries and food, alleged that they were instead subjected to violence, hunger and confinement.

Jagdish, a resident of Sitapur, said he was held at the factory for 11 months and beaten whenever he asked to return home. “My salary was fixed at Rs 12,000, but I never received any money. We were forced to work day and night and hardly got any sleep,” he said after being rescued.

The workers alleged that they had been promised monthly wages ranging from Rs 8,000 to Rs 12,000 for manufacturing dona-pattal, disposable bowls and plates widely



used across north India. However, shortly after arriving at the factory, their mobile phones, Aadhaar cards and other identity documents were allegedly confiscated.

Ramu, a worker from Nainital, claimed that the labourers were denied proper food and contact with their families. He alleged that workers were fed poor-quality rotis and were frequently assaulted with belts and iron rods.

According to the rescued labourers, they were made to work long hours without wages and were often fed only once a day. Requests for wages, food or medical treatment allegedly resulted in beatings.

Police said medical examinations revealed fractures, wounds and other injuries on some of the workers.

The labourers also alleged that pit bull dogs stationed inside and outside the factory premises were used to prevent escape.

The case came to light after one worker managed to escape and alert the police. A joint team of police, labour department officials and district authorities subsequently raided the factory and rescued 13 workers.

Senior Superintendent of Police Sanjay Verma said the victims had been brought from Bihar, Jharkhand, West Bengal, Uttar Pradesh and Nepal on the promise of jobs.

Police have arrested Shiva Tyagi and Pradeep Baliyan, while factory operator Ankit Baliyan remains absconding. Officials said the investigation is continuing.



EDITORIAL
ETHICAL
BOUNDARIES

The Union government's decision to tighten the regulatory framework governing foreign contributions to non-governmental organisations has once again brought the Foreign Contribution (Regulation) Act (FCRA) into public debate. While critics often portray such measures as restrictions on civil society, the government argues that they are necessary to ensure transparency, accountability and national interest. The latest emphasis on scrutinising organisations allegedly involved in religious conversion activities reflects a broader concern that foreign funding, when linked to faith-based mobilisation, can sometimes move beyond charitable or developmental work and enter areas that have significant social and political implications. The debate, therefore, extends beyond finance and regulation. It touches upon questions of religious freedom, social harmony, national sovereignty and the role of foreign influence in domestic affairs.

India's relationship with foreign-funded organisations has always been shaped by caution. The FCRA itself was first enacted in 1976 during a period when policymakers were concerned about external actors influencing political and social processes within the country. The law was substantially revised in 2010 and further strengthened in recent years to address emerging challenges in financial flows and regulatory oversight. The principle behind the legislation is straightforward. Organisations receiving foreign funds are free to undertake legitimate charitable, educational, humanitarian or developmental activities, but such contributions should not be used in ways that undermine public order, political stability or national interests. In a country as large and diverse as India, where faith, identity and community relations remain deeply intertwined, governments of different political persuasions have historically maintained that external funding linked to religious activities requires closer scrutiny than ordinary welfare programmes.

The renewed focus on religious conversion stems from allegations that some organisations have used foreign contributions to support activities that blur the distinction between social service and faith-based persuasion. Supporters of stricter enforcement argue that when aid, education, healthcare or welfare benefits are tied directly or indirectly to religious conversion efforts, questions arise about the voluntariness of individual choice. India's Constitution guarantees freedom of religion and the right to profess, practise and propagate faith. At the same time, several states have enacted laws against conversion through force, fraud or inducement. The challenge for regulators lies in determining whether foreign-funded activities remain within the realm of lawful religious expression or cross into practices that violate existing legal safeguards. The government's argument is that monitoring financial flows is essential because the source and purpose of funding can reveal whether organisations are engaged in genuine charitable work or pursuing objectives that may create social tensions.

The issue becomes even more complex when viewed against the backdrop of India's social diversity. Religious organisations have historically played an important role in education, healthcare, disaster relief and welfare services. Across faith traditions, institutions run by religious groups have contributed significantly to social development, often reaching communities where state capacity remains limited. Excessive regulation can therefore create concerns that legitimate humanitarian work may suffer. Many civil society groups argue that burdensome compliance requirements and licence cancellations can weaken voluntary organisations that provide valuable services. They caution that the regulatory environment must not become so restrictive that it discourages philanthropy or undermines genuine community development initiatives. These concerns deserve serious consideration because a vibrant civil society is an essential component of any democratic society.

Yet it is equally important to recognise that transparency is not inherently opposed to freedom. In most democratic countries, foreign funding of political, religious or advocacy organisations is subject to some level of disclosure and oversight. Governments across the world increasingly seek to understand how external financial flows influence domestic institutions, public opinion and social movements. India is not unique in this regard. The rapid expansion of global networks, digital communication and transnational funding channels has heightened concerns about external influence in many nations. The government's position is that organisations receiving foreign contributions must be able to demonstrate clearly how funds are used, who benefits from them and whether their activities comply with Indian law. From this perspective, stricter enforcement of FCRA provisions is presented not as a restriction on civil society but as a mechanism to ensure public accountability.

The larger challenge is to strike a balance between vigilance and openness. Regulatory measures should be precise, transparent and evidence-based rather than broad or arbitrary. If organisations are found to have violated the law, action should be proportionate and supported by due process. Equally, genuine charitable institutions should not face uncertainty simply because they receive funding from abroad. The credibility of the regulatory system ultimately depends on consistency and fairness. Public confidence grows when enforcement is guided by clear legal standards rather than political considerations. For India, which aspires to strengthen both democratic institutions and social cohesion, the objective should be neither unrestricted foreign funding nor excessive state control, but a framework that promotes transparency while protecting legitimate freedoms.

The renewed attention to FCRA compliance and religious conversion reflects a wider debate about how an increasingly interconnected world intersects with domestic social realities. Foreign contributions can support valuable development work, but they can also raise questions when linked to sensitive issues such as faith and identity. The government's decision to tighten oversight indicates its belief that national sovereignty and social harmony require closer monitoring of such activities. Whether one agrees with the extent of the measures or not, the underlying principle is likely to remain relevant: transparency in foreign funding is not merely an administrative requirement but an important safeguard in a diverse democracy seeking to balance freedom, accountability and public trust.

NEXUS
OF GOOD



ANIL SWARUP

THE WRITER IS
AN AUTHOR AND
A FORMER
CIVIL SERVANT

In an era where governments across the world are exploring artificial intelligence and digital governance, Dhule district in Maharashtra has emerged as a pioneering laboratory of administrative innovation

Dhule's Digital Governance Revolution

From AI-powered decision-making to real-time citizen services, Dhule's e-Suvidha platform is redefining how district administration delivers accountability, efficiency and transparency

Technology can be a game-changer in administration and governance. This is being aptly demonstrated in Dhule District, Maharashtra, under the visionary leadership of a young Collector, Bhagyashree Vispute. She has put in place a Unified Gateway for officers. It is a single workflow system used by every officer across Dhule district, from Gramsevak and Talathi at the village level up to the District Collector. All four talukas (Shirpur, Dhule, Sakri and Shindkheda), along with their Tehsil offices, Panchayat Samitis and Sub-Divisional offices, are mapped. All district departments (Revenue, Education, Health, Agriculture, Social Welfare, Public Works, Water Resources and others) are integrated. Any officer can assign a task to any office, set a deadline and monitor progress in real time. Missed deadlines trigger automatic escalation. Every action is recorded with a full audit trail.

It is enabling a transformation:

- ▶ Eliminates silos between offices and departments.
- ▶ Enables inter-departmental work to be processed in parallel instead of sequentially.
- ▶ Builds end-to-end accountability through audit trails.
- ▶ Reduces file movement delays from weeks or months to hours or days.
- ▶ Gives senior officers a live view of work across the district without needing manual status reports.

The initiative includes a self-hosted Large Language Model with full data sovereignty. The AI engine powering e-Suvidha is hosted entirely on government infrastructure. No government data or citizen information is shared with any external entity. The model is trained on Government Resolutions, departmental handbooks, circulars and administrative guidelines covering Revenue, Land Records, Social Welfare, Education, Health, Agriculture, Tribal Development, Urban Administration and other key areas. This facilitates:

- ▶ Complete data sovereignty for sensitive citizen and administrative data.
- ▶ No dependence on external AI providers or commercial APIs.
- ▶ Sets a precedent for secure, government-owned AI for other districts and states.
- ▶ Removes legal and privacy risks that come with sending data to third-party AI systems.

The GR Sarathi (AI-powered conversational assistant) is a ChatGPT-



Under Collector Bhagyashree Vispute, Dhule has built a pioneering digital governance platform integrating every office

like interface designed for government officers. Any officer can type or speak a query in Marathi or English, such as, "What is the procedure for emergency land acquisition under the 2013 Act?" or "Which GR governs drought relief disbursement?", and receive within seconds the precise GR number, relevant sections, applicable procedure, required documentation and designated authority. The system reads, understands and synthesises information into contextual answers. This:

- ▶ Reduces time spent searching for the correct GR from hours or days to seconds.
- ▶ Removes the risk of officers applying outdated or incorrect GRs.
- ▶ Democratise institutional knowledge that earlier took years of postings to absorb.
- ▶ Gives newly posted officers the same quality of guidance as senior colleagues from day one.
- ▶ Reduces dependence on senior officers for procedural clarifications.
- ▶ Improves consistency of administrative decisions across the district.

The AI drafting system put in place automates the preparation of government orders, circulars and official correspondence. Drafts are produced in minutes in both Marathi and English, referencing the correct GRs through GR Sarathi and following prescribed formats. It:

- ▶ Reduces drafting time per letter from up to an hour to a few minutes.
- ▶ Frees up an estimated 20 to 25 officer-hours per day at the Collector's office alone, where 40 to 50 letters are dispatched daily.
- ▶ Ensures GR citations and formats are accurate and standardised.
- ▶ Redirects saved officer-hours to direct citizen service.

The Meeting Management System uses AI to generate meeting minutes in Marathi immediately after proceedings conclude. The system then automatically converts decisions into tasks, assigns them to mapped offices with deadlines and triggers reminders. This:

- ▶ Eliminates delays in circulating minutes.
- ▶ Ensures every meeting decision becomes a tracked task instead of being lost in notes.
- ▶ Removes the gap between deciding and doing.
- ▶ Creates a permanent, searchable record of what was discussed and what was assigned.

The Field Visit Tracking System maintains a digital record of every inspection, with GPS verification of location. Instructions issued in the field are converted into tracked tasks and monitored to completion. When an officer revisits a location, all previous instructions and their completion status are available instantly. It:

- ▶ Replaces episodic field reviews with continuous accountability.
 - ▶ Prevents repeat issues at the same location from going unaddressed.
 - ▶ Verifies that officers actually visited the locations they claim to have visited.
 - ▶ Builds a longitudinal record of field administration that travels with the location, not the officer.
- Under the Citizen Application Tracking System, every application received across every office is given a digital tracking number. Real-time status is visible to citizens at any time, and applications pending beyond the stipulated period escalate automatically. This:
- ▶ Eliminates the need for citizens to physically visit offices to check status.

- ▶ Removes uncertainty about whether an application has been received or acted upon.
- ▶ Forces timely action through automatic escalation.
- ▶ Builds citizen trust through visible, predictable progress.

A dedicated module allows MPs, MLAs and Ministers to forward citizen grievances directly through the system to the concerned office and track progress at every stage until resolution. It:

- ▶ Bridges the coordination gap between elected representatives and the administration.
- ▶ Ensures grievances raised through representatives receive the same systematic tracking as direct applications.
- ▶ Provides representatives with verifiable status updates for their constituents.
- ▶ Reduces ad hoc follow-up calls and letters between political offices and the bureaucracy.

A dedicated WhatsApp number accepts text and voice notes in Marathi, Hindi and English. Citizens can attach documents, submit applications and track status around the clock. No separate app installation or registration is required. The channel is powered by the same AI engine, so questions on schemes, eligibility and procedures are answered instantly. It:

- ▶ Uses a platform citizens already have and trust on their phones.
- ▶ Provides 24x7 access to district administration without staffing a call centre.
- ▶ Removes the need for separate app downloads and registrations.
- ▶ Scales effortlessly across languages and citizen segments.

The Performance Analytics platform generates department-wise and officer-wise data on task completion rates, average response times, pending workloads and escalation frequency. It:

- ▶ Enables data-driven administrative reviews at every level.
- ▶ Surfaces bottlenecks and underperforming offices that would otherwise remain hidden.
- ▶ Allows recognition of officers and teams based on measurable performance.
- ▶ Replaces anecdotal reviews with objective metrics.

These initiatives are already transforming governance in the district. They present a wonderful example of the Nexus of Good. The model should be replicated in other districts across the country.

Views expressed are personal

LEARNING
LEAP



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From new IITs and AIIMS to digital learning and global collaborations, India's higher education story is being rewritten

India's Higher Education Renaissance

Over the last twelve years, India's higher education ecosystem has expanded rapidly, combining access, quality, research, innovation, employability and global competitiveness

During the last twelve years, India's higher education landscape has undergone a remarkable transformation in terms of accessibility, quality, and technological innovation. Prior to 2014, the primary focus of the Indian education system was expanding access, but over the last 12 years, it has emerged as a globally competitive ecosystem emphasising employability, innovation, entrepreneurship, and research excellence.

The scale of expansion in higher education institutions itself is unprecedented. Since 2014, India has added seven new Indian Institutes of Technology (IITs), nine Indian Institutes of Management (IIMs), sixteen Indian Institutes of Information Technology (IIITs), and approximately fifteen new All India Institutes of Medical Sciences (AIIMS). During the same period, the number of universities increased from around 760 to more than 1,330, representing an addition of over 570 universities nationwide.

The expansion of premier institutions has significantly improved regional equity. New IITs were established in Tirupati, Palakkad, Bhilai, Goa, Jammu, Dhanbad, and Dharwad, while new IIMs emerged in Nagpur, Sambalpur, Bodh Gaya, Jammu, Sirmour, Visakhapatnam, Amritsar, Mumbai, and Guwahati. Similarly, the network of IIITs expanded from 10 to 26 institutions, strengthening India's capacity in digital technologies and advanced computing.

Medical education witnessed equally impressive growth. Medical colleges increased from approximately 387 to nearly 780 institutions, while the AIIMS network expanded across several states, dramatically improving access to quality healthcare education and services.

During the same period, there has been a significant rise in student enrolment in higher education. The Gross Enrolment Ratio (GER), which



New institutions, rising enrolment, and stronger research are reshaping India's academic future

was around 23.7 per cent, has now increased to over 28 per cent. Millions of additional students, particularly women and learners from underserved regions and underprivileged social groups, have entered the higher education system.

One of the most significant changes in India's higher education system has been a noticeable shift from degree-oriented education to employability-oriented learning. Universities and other higher education institutions today emphasise internships, live industry projects, experiential learning, entrepreneurship, skill certifications, and multidisciplinary education. Programmes in Data Science, Artificial Intelligence, Machine Learning, FinTech, Cybersecurity, Business Analytics, and Sustainability have become highly sought-after across academic institutions.

India's higher education institutions are increasingly aligned with the needs of Industry 4.0 and the digital economy. Industry-academia collabora-

tions have helped strengthen curriculum design, research partnerships, innovation laboratories, internships, and placement opportunities. Such collaborations are now defining a new momentum in many higher education institutions by solving real-life problems of society.

The country's global academic standing has also improved considerably. Indian institutions are now increasingly visible in international ranking systems such as QS and Times Higher Education Rankings. IITs, IIMs, and leading universities have enhanced their reputation through stronger research output, innovation ecosystems, and global collaborations.

Research and innovation have emerged as central pillars of institutional development. Universities are now evaluated not only by enrolment and teaching quality but also by publications, citations, patents, startup creation, technology transfer, and societal impact. Incubation centres and inno-

vation hubs have become common features across campuses, encouraging students and faculty to pursue entrepreneurial ventures.

Another historic development has been the internationalisation of Indian higher education. Recent reforms have enabled globally recognised foreign universities to establish campuses and academic partnerships in India. Similarly, leading educational institutions from India, both public and private, have opened their overseas campuses. This marks a significant change in India's positioning in higher education because the country has now emerged as a global education destination.

India's digital transformation capabilities have further accelerated the country's progress in educational attainment. Online learning platforms, virtual laboratories, hybrid classrooms, academic credit banks, and technology-enabled teaching methods have enhanced flexibility and accessibility for learners. The integration of technology into education has expanded learning opportunities far beyond traditional classroom boundaries.

The efforts of educators have been well supplemented by institutional reforms and far-reaching policies. In 2020, the Union Government came out with a new and apt policy for the country's education sector in the form of the National Education Policy (NEP) 2020. NEP 2020 aims to transform India's higher education system by making it flexible, multidisciplinary, and globally aligned, and has the ambitious goal of increasing the GER to 50 per cent by 2035. Overall, in the last 12 years, India's higher education system has made stupendous progress across almost all key indicators of education and is now poised for momentous growth, aligning with the Prime Minister's vision of a Viksit Bharat.

Views expressed are personal

SENSEX JUMPS 790 POINTS

Mkts rebound on softening oil prices

OUR CORRESPONDENT

MUMBAI: Benchmark equity indices Sensex and Nifty rebounded sharply by around 1 per cent on Wednesday, propelled by softening crude oil prices and hectic buying in bank, financial and IT shares.

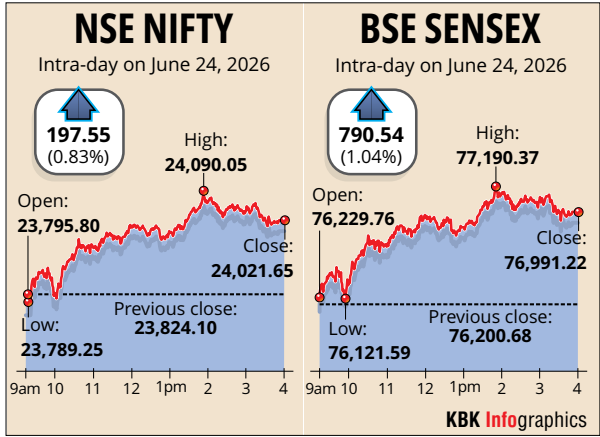
Besides, growing expectations of an India-US trade deal and foreign funds turning net buyers in the domestic market supported the firm trend in equities, traders said.

The 30-share BSE Sensex jumped 790.54 points, or 1.04 per cent, to settle at 76,991.22. During the day, it surged 989.69 points, or 1.29 per cent, to 77,190.37.

A total of 2,215 stocks advanced, while 2,034 declined and 181 remained unchanged on the BSE.

The 50-share NSE Nifty climbed 197.55 points, or 0.83 per cent, to end at 24,021.65.

From the Sensex pack, InterGlobe Aviation, Trent, Tech Mahindra, Bajaj Finance, ICICI Bank, Infosys, HDFC Bank and Tata Consultancy



Services were among the major winners.

In contrast, NTPC, Tata Steel, Maruti and Bharat Electronics were among the laggards.

The BSE SmallCap Select index edged higher by 0.44 per cent, and the MidCap Select index went up by 0.32 per cent.

Sectorally, the BSE Private Banks index climbed 2.21 per cent, Realty (2.17 per cent), Services (2.14 per cent), IT (1.81 per cent), Bankex (1.78

per cent), Focused IT (1.68 per cent) and MidSmall Private Banks Quality Tilt (1.64 per cent).

Industrials, Telecommunication, Utilities (0.79 per cent), and Power were among the laggards.

“The surge came on the back of falling prices of crude oil amidst relief about the situation between the USA and Iran, as well as the possibility of uninterrupted energy flow through the Strait of Hormuz.

HIGHLIGHTS

» A total of 2,215 stocks advanced, while 2,034 declined and 181 remained unchanged on the BSE

» The 50-share NSE Nifty climbed 197.55 points, or 0.83 per cent, to end at 24,021.65

» Foreign Institutional Investors (FIIs) bought equities worth Rs 17.86 crore on Tuesday

Favourable international factors, foreign institutional investors’ purchases, strength in bank stocks, and IT companies were other positive factors for the market,” Vikram Kasat, Head Advisory, PL Capital, said.

Brent crude, the global oil benchmark, dropped 1.69 per cent to USD 75.78 per barrel.

Foreign Institutional Investors (FIIs) bought equities worth Rs 17.86 crore on Tuesday, according to exchange

data. A senior US official has said that the United States and India are “very, very close” to concluding a historic bilateral trade deal that will open the 1.4 billion-strong Indian market to American goods on reciprocal and mutually beneficial terms.

“Indian equity markets rebounded sharply from the previous session’s sell-off, led by strong gains in banking stocks and a recovery in the IT sector. Sentiment improved as easing geopolitical tensions in the Middle East, and a further decline in crude oil prices helped restore risk appetite and support broader market participation,” Ponnudi R, CEO of Enrich Money, an online trading and wealth tech firm, said.

In Asian markets, South Korea’s Kospi climbed over 3 per cent after a steep decline in the previous trading session. Shanghai’s SSE Composite index and Hong Kong’s Hang Seng index also settled higher, while Japan’s Nikkei 225 index ended lower.

Markets in Europe were trading on a mixed note.

Premature to discuss rate hike at this stage, says Guv

NEW DELHI: Reserve Bank Governor Sanjay Malhotra has said the central bank is closely monitoring developments in West Asia and that it would be premature to talk about a rate hike at this stage.

“If we actually wanted to prepare them (market) for this (rate hike), then we would have changed our (stance)..., if it was so certain that we are going to hike in the coming months, then we would have changed the stance from ‘neutral’ to ‘restrictive’, right? We did not do that,” he told ET Now.

“So, I think it will be premature to talk about a rate hike. What we have said is that we are cautious, and we are aware that there could be risks, both on inflation, as well as on growth, especially inflation, because it is hitting the upper band...we are cautious, and we will continue to remain data dependent,” he said.

Earlier this month, the RBI kept its benchmark repo rate unchanged at 5.25 per cent



amid growing risks to growth and inflation from the prolonged West Asia conflict, elevated energy prices and global supply-chain disruptions.

Observing that the de-escalation in the West Asia conflict is a big positive for the whole world and also for the Indian economy, Malhotra said it is good news both for growth and inflation. Besides, he said, crude prices have moderated, and urea prices have also plummeted, providing comfort to the Indian economy.

Stressing that the Indian economy is resilient, he said: “The government and the OMCs (Oil Marketing Companies) together cushioned the impact of the energy shock to a great

extent, and all high frequency indicators show that India has weathered the shock quite well in very uncertain times”.

“And as we said, in our monetary policy, we are in wait-and-watch mode. Let’s see how long this truce continues and better times ahead for all of us,” he said.

While acknowledging that risks have moderated, he cautioned that policymakers were not yet ready to draw definitive conclusions on the inflation outlook. “Upside risks have certainly reduced, but we’ll have to...wait and watch as to where crude prices ultimately end up,” he said.

On inflation, the governor said the RBI was closely monitoring whether fuel-led wholesale price pressures spread to the broader economy.

“We are not sure, frankly, as to whether we will have second-round effects or not. If you were sure, the monetary policy committee would have acted,” he said.

London: India, UK set to discuss implementation of free trade agreement

NEW DELHI: Trade ministers of India and the UK will hold discussions this week in London on issues related to implementation of the comprehensive economic and trade agreement (CETA), which is scheduled to come into force on July 15.

Commerce and Industry minister Piyush Goyal will undertake an official visit to London from June 25-27 for the discussions, an official statement said on Wednesday.

During the visit, Goyal will hold a high-level bilateral meeting with UK’s Secretary of State for Business and Trade Peter Kyle.

“The bilateral discussions will focus on aligning regulatory roadmaps, streamlining cross-border customs coordination and finalising administrative mechanisms to facilitate the smooth implementation of CETA and the DCC (Double Contribution Convention),” the commerce ministry said.

The ministers will review preparedness for the implementation of CETAs tariff liberalisation commitments, which will provide enhanced market access opportunities for Indian exports in the United Kingdom, it added.

It said that discussions will also cover the operational roadmap for the DCC, which is expected to establish a streamlined mechanism to address dual social security contribution requirements for eligible temporary workers.

“The two sides will further discuss the operationalisation of mutual market access com-



Piyush Goyal will undertake an official visit to London from June 25-27

mitments across key services sectors and review measures aimed at strengthening bilateral trade and investment ties,” it said.

Goyal will also participate in a series of Government-to-Business engagements with industry leaders, investors and corporate representatives.

He will meet senior executives of leading global companies, including HSBC (Global Trade Solutions) and Rolls-Royce, to discuss strategic investments, industrial collaboration and the expansion of manufacturing partnerships in India.

Further, he will attend a session hosted by the UK-India Business Council (UKIBC). The engagement will bring together C-suite executives and representatives from leading multinational companies, including Tata Group, HSBC, Prudential, De Beers and Baker McKenzie, to discuss opportunities for trade, investment and business collaborations.

BSE seeks Rajesh Exports’ response on ED searches

NEW DELHI: The Bombay Stock Exchange (BSE) on Wednesday sought a clarification from gold jewellery firm Rajesh Exports Ltd over reports of searches conducted by the Enforcement Directorate (ED) at multiple locations linked to the Bengaluru-based company.

The exchange’s query came a day after the central agency searched nine premises connected to the firm under the provisions of the Foreign Exchange Management Act (FEMA).

“The reply is awaited,” Rajesh Exports said in a regulatory filing.

The development marks a fresh escalation in the legal troubles surrounding the company, which is already facing allegations of a massive finan-

The company is already facing allegations of a massive financial fraud levelled by the Securities and Exchange Board of India (Sebi)

cial fraud levelled by the Securities and Exchange Board of India (Sebi).

Rajesh Mehta, the company’s Founder and Chairman, recently denied any fund diversion or wrongdoing in an interview. He said the firm would fully cooperate with the fresh forensic audit ordered by Sebi and would not challenge the market regulator’s interim order against it.

Institutional investors put in bids worth Rs 1,900 crore in IRFC OFS

MPOST BUREAU

NEW DELHI: Institutional investors on Wednesday put in bids worth over Rs 1,900 crore for Indian Railway Finance Corporation (IRFC) shares in its offer for sale, over-subscribing the portion reserved for them. Non-retail investors placed bids for over 21.87 crore IRFC shares, or 1.86 times of the 11.76 crore shares reserved for them. Indicative price for the bids is Rs 91.10 per share, stock exchange data showed.

The government is selling up to 2 per cent stake or 26.13 crore shares in IRFC at a floor price of Rs 91/share. The OFS includes a greenshoe option of



1 per cent stake.

Department of Investment and Public Asset Management (DIPAM) Secretary Arunish Chawla said the OFS has received “enthusiastic response from the investors”.

“The government has decided to exercise the green shoe option. Retail investors and employees get to bid on Thursday, 25th June 2026,” Chawla said. At the floor price, bids for over 21.87 crore IRFC

shares are valued at over Rs 1,900 crore. The floor price of Rs 91/share was set at a discount of 7.8 per cent over Tuesday’s closing price of IRFC shares on the BSE. Shares of IRFC closed 6.24 per cent lower at Rs 92.53 on the BSE on Wednesday.

In the current fiscal year, the government has sold minority stakes in five central public sector enterprises, banks and insurance companies, taking the total disinvestment proceeds to Rs 16,480 crore so far. This includes Rs 5,542 crore from Coal India, Rs 4,357 crore from NHPC, Rs 3,090 crore from GIC, Rs 2,266 crore from Central Bank of India and Rs 1,223 crore from NLC India.

Oil prices may hinge on China even after Hormuz reopens permanently

‘Beijing managed to cushion impact of supply disruptions by cutting imports’

NEW DELHI: As the United States and Iran negotiate a permanent reopening of the Strait of Hormuz and the restoration of Middle Eastern oil supplies, analysts say China has emerged as a key factor influencing global oil markets despite remaining outside the diplomatic process.

China, the world’s second-largest crude oil consumer, has managed to cushion the impact of supply disruptions caused by the conflict involving Iran, which has affected access to more than 11 million barrels of oil per day. By reducing imports, drawing on strategic reserves and accelerating the shift towards clean energy, Beijing has helped limit the impact of higher oil prices both domestically and globally.

Despite supply losses estimated at more than one billion barrels during the conflict, crude prices have remained relatively stable. Earlier forecasts had suggested oil prices could rise to as high as \$200 a barrel, but analysts say Chi-

KEY POINTS

- » Despite supply losses estimated at more than one billion barrels during the conflict, crude prices have remained relatively stable
- » Earlier forecasts had suggested oil prices could rise to as high as \$200 a barrel, but analysts say China’s actions have prevented a sharper escalation



na’s actions have prevented a sharper escalation, CNN reported.

Daan Walter, principal at energy think tank Ember, said China had played a crucial role in buffering the rest of Asia from the impact of supply disruptions, thereby supporting the global economy.

Analysts at Societe Generale noted that while the 1973 Arab oil embargo, which affected about 7 per cent of global supply, triggered a 134 per cent increase in oil prices, the present conflict has disrupted around 14 per cent of global supply without causing a comparable surge.

China has reportedly cut crude imports by nearly three million barrels a day, an amount roughly equal to Japan’s total oil demand. The country had built up substantial inventories through discounted purchases of Russian and Iranian crude and now holds more than one billion barrels in commercial and strategic reserves.

At the same time, Beijing has restricted exports of refined fuels to safeguard domestic supplies. The rapid adoption of electric vehicles has also reduced oil demand, with the International Energy Agency estimating that Chi-

na’s EV fleet cut oil consumption by about one million barrels per day last year.

Analysts, however, warn that the same stockpiles that helped Beijing stabilise the market have been drawn down. Those inventories will eventually need replenishment. That is where China’s next move becomes critical.

If prices soften further, China will likely return as a significant buyer, influencing the prices, say analysts, adding that Beijing’s energy policies will remain critical to the global oil market even after the Strait of Hormuz fully reopens.

‘Shift from licencing regime’: DoT notifies new authorisation norms

NEW DELHI: The government has notified rules that operationalise a new authorisation-based framework in the telecom sector, marking a transition from the legacy licencing regime. The Centre has also notified the ‘Telecom eServices Portal’ that enables the digital implementation of the provisions of the Telecom Act.

A set of norms have been notified under the Telecom Act, among them, the Telecom-munications (Authorisation for Provision of Main Telecom-munication Services) Rules, 2025, that effectively shift entities from the old licence regime to a new authorisation-based framework. Existing Unified Licence, UASL, ISP, NLD and ILD licensees can migrate to the new regime.

The draft of the rules pertaining to the authorisation-based framework was published on September 5, 2025, inviting objections and suggestions from stakeholders within 30 days - a window that was later extended to October 21, 2025. “...comments and suggestions received in that period in respect of the said draft rules have been considered by the Central Government,” the noti-

INSIGHT

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» Existing Unified Licence, UASL, ISP, NLD and ILD



licensees can migrate to the new regime

fication by the Telecom Department said. The rules allow any eligible entity to apply to the government for authorisation to provide telecom services either as a network service operator, a virtual network operator (VNO), or both.

“Any person may apply to the Central Government under rule 6 to obtain authorisation, as network service operator or virtual network operator or both, to provide one or more telecommunication services that are within the scope and service area of any authorisation specified,” it said.

This includes unified service authorisation for a national service area, access service authorisation for one or more service areas, wireline access service authorisation,

internet service authorisation for a national service area or one or more service areas, and long-distance service authorisation for a national service area. According to the rules, any company wanting to establish, operate, or expand a satellite network must separately seek government permission and provide details of satellites, space capacity and gateway infrastructure.

“Every new authorised entity intending to establish, operate, maintain or expand a satellite network, or to provide principal telecommunication service using a satellite network, shall apply for permission of the Central Government, in such form and manner as specified on the portal,” it said.

IRCTC CMD Sanjay Kumar Jain to demit office on Jul 20

NEW DELHI: IRCTC Chairman and Managing Director Sanjay Kumar Jain will demit office on July 20 after the Ministry of Railways accepted his resignation, submitted on personal grounds, on Tuesday.

Jain took charge as CMD in February 2024. During his tenure, IRCTC was elevated from ‘Schedule B’ to ‘Schedule A’ status and from ‘Mini Ratna-II’ to ‘Navratna’ status. The company also recorded its highest-ever financial performance in 2025-26, with revenue touching Rs 5,215 crore. Tourism revenue reached a record Rs 890 crore during the fiscal

Several initiatives, including AI-based monitoring of base kitchens, expansion of e-Pantry services and technology-driven improvements in e-ticketing, were introduced during his tenure. Before joining IRCTC, Jain served in key positions in the Railways and the Department of Public Enterprises. The Railways Ministry said orders regarding additional charge of the CMD post would be issued separately.



Reese Witherspoon's advice helped Lexi Minetree understand the heart of Elle Woods

'ELLE WOODS ALWAYS TAKES THE HIGH ROAD'

OUR CORRESPONDENT

A head of its highly anticipated premiere on 'Prime Video', 'Elle' revisits the early life of Elle Woods, years before audiences first met her in 'Legally Blonde'. The coming-of-age prequel follows a younger Elle as she navigates high school, friendships, heartbreak and the experiences that shape her into the confident, optimistic woman audiences know and love.

Like many people, Lexi Minetree grew up with Elle Woods. So, when she landed the role, she threw herself into understanding every part of the character, from the way she speaks and carries herself to the qualities that have made audiences love her for nearly 25 years.

Speaking about her preparation for the role, Lexi shared, "I must have watched 'Legally Blonde' over 150 times during the casting process and then even more after I got the role. At one point, I could probably do a one-woman show of it."

"For me, I didn't just want to get her attitude and resilience and charm. I really wanted to nail her voice, mannerisms and movement. That's such an important part of the character. It would be so easy to play her as a stereotype or do a valley girl accent, but Elle doesn't have any of that.



'I really wanted to nail her voice, mannerisms and movement,' says Lexi

moment she pointed out from the movie: when Elle is talking to Warner after everything and he suddenly wants her back. She has every opportunity to call him out and she doesn't. She never goes low. She always takes the high road. She's never a bully, even to people who are unkind to her. Reese reminded me of that and for me, that's the core of who Elle is. I try to hold onto that in scenes when she could easily lash out."

Created by Laura Kittrell, season one of 'Elle' includes Lexi Minetree as Elle Woods, June Diane Raphael as Elle's mother Eva and Tom Everett Scott as her father Wyatt, alongside Jacob Moskovitz, Gabrielle Policano, Chandler Kinney, Zac Looker, and Amy Pietz.

'Elle' will premiere exclusively on July 1.

'We hit it off instantly right from the reading sessions'

'Made in India...' continues to strike a chord with audiences

OUR CORRESPONDENT

As 'Made in India: A Titan Story' continues to strike a chord with audiences across the nation on 'Amazon MX Player', viewers have been particularly drawn to the relationships, ambitions and defining moments that shape the narrative. For Vaibhav Tatwawadi, who essays the role of Akash, the experience of bringing the story to life was marked by moments that underscored both the magnitude of the world being recreated and the camaraderie that developed behind the scenes.

Reflecting on a memory from the shoot that left a lasting impression, Vaibhav shared, "There was a scene where we were supposed to show the expanse of the Hosur plant and I remember the lights were going to turn on one by one as I delivered my dialogue. Looking at the sheer scale of it all, I realised this was not something ordinary; it was something truly remarkable. That was the moment when the scale of the story really hit me, and I



Vaibhav Tatwawadi talked about his camaraderie with Jim Sarbh in 'Made in India: A Titan Story'

knew we were creating something very special."

Speaking about his experience working alongside Jim Sarbh, who portrays Xerxes Desai, Vaibhav added, "We

hit it off instantly right from the reading sessions. There was a wonderful camaraderie between us and I think that naturally translated on screen as well. Chemistry comes from the comfort and trust you share off-screen. We were genuinely comfortable around each other and there was a great deal of mutual respect. I'm really glad that audiences are connecting with the friendship, the banter and the moments Akash and Xerxes share throughout the series."

Keanu Reeves to feature in 'Lego' film



Hollywood star Keanu Reeves is in negotiations to feature in a live-action hybrid 'Lego' film.

The 'Universal' film is directed by Josh Cooley and also reunites the actor with the filmmaker after their collaboration on the 2019 'Toy Story 4', where Cooley directed and Reeves voiced the stuntman toy Duke Caboom. It will be produced by Jill Wilfert and Ryan Christians under the banner of 'The Lego Group'. The plot details are kept under wraps, but reportedly, the film will be a combination of live-action and animation, according to the entertainment news outlet 'Deadline'.

'Universal' signed a five-year exclusive deal with 'The Lego Group' in 2020 to develop, produce and distribute theatrical releases. Previously, there have been four major Lego films, including 'The Lego Movie' (2014), 'The Lego Batman Movie' (2017), 'The Lego Ninjago Movie' (2017) and 'The Lego Movie 2: The Second Part', which was released in 2019.

Reeves' latest work is 'Outcome', which was released on 'Apple TV' on April 10. He will next voice the character of anti-hero Shadow the Hedgehog in 'Sonic the Hedgehog 4'. He will also feature in the 'Constantine' sequel and Netflix's 'BRZRKR' film.

The 'Universal' film is directed by Josh Cooley

I am truly honoured: R Madhavan

The actor is grateful for receiving the Padma Shri, the fourth-highest civilian award in India

R Madhavan is deeply honoured and grateful for receiving Padma Shri, the fourth-highest civilian award in India.

The actor, known for his acclaimed performances in films such as 'Rang De Basanti', 'Vikram Vedha', '3 Idiots', 'Tanu Weds Manu' and others, was awarded the honour by President Droupadi Murmu on Tuesday in Delhi.

Madhavan was awarded in recognition of his outstanding and distinguished contributions to Indian cinema across multiple languages and genres. The actor shared a picture from the ceremony on his 'Instagram' handle, which featured him receiving the award and thanked his supporters and audience.

"I am deeply humbled and profoundly grateful and truly honoured to be conferred with the Padma Shri. My heartfelt gratitude to the Government of India for bestowing upon me one of our nation's highest civilian honours. I am equally thankful to the Government of Maharashtra for recommending my name and placing their faith in my journey. This recognition is something I will cherish for the rest of my life," he wrote in the caption.



Madhavan said that the recognition reminds him of a greater duty

He added, "To every person who watched my films, embraced my characters, celebrated my successes, forgave my shortcomings and stood by me through the years - this honour belongs as much to you as it does to me. Your affection has been the driving force behind every milestone in my life and career. Today, I also feel a deep sense of responsibility."

The actor, who recently featured in 'Dhurandhar: The Revenge', said the recognition reminds him of a greater duty. "This recognition reminds me that every privilege carries with it a greater duty - to uphold the values of integrity, humility and excellence; to contribute meaningfully to the world of cinema that has given me everything; and to serve my country in whatever way I can," he said.

'It is a scary thought'

Filmmaker Tom Hanks said the studio can replace his voice as Sheriff Woody in 'Toy Story' films with artificial intelligence and calls it a 'scary thought'.

Hanks has voiced the character of a pull-string cowboy doll in all the instalments of the franchise and is sure that, if the studio decides to, it has enough materials to replicate the voice with AI.

"Time is undefeated. The question would be whether or not we could cobble together some version of me. Every word we have ever recorded in time in 'Toy Story' is on digital media somewhere, so they could put together anything they would want," he told 'Entertainment Weekly' in an interview.

Asked if he would voice the character in the sixth film, Hanks said it should be worthwhile. "If you're gonna do another 'Toy Story', it better be worthwhile. It better be great. You'd better be examining some theme that is not just dragging it out because people like the title," he said.

He added, "I mean, it is a huge corporate business without a doubt. I'm not gonna discount that.



Tom Hanks quipped that the studio could replace his voice with AI in 'Toy Story' films

But unless it's good, new and fresh, there's no reason to do it at all."

'Toy Story 5' was released on June 19 and emerged as the highest opening weekend grosser at the global box office in the franchise. The film is directed by Andrew Stanton, with McKenna Harris serving as the co-director.

The film also featured Tim Allen as Buzz Lightyear, Joan Cusack as Jessie, Annie Potts as Bo Peep and John Ratzenberger as Hamm.

AKSHAY KUMAR ON THE GENRE OF COMEDY

'IN THE AGE OF MEMES AND REELS, COMEDY HAS BECOME MORE CHALLENGING'

Akshay Kumar is gearing up for the release of the comedy film 'Welcome To The Jungle'

Superstar Akshay Kumar said it has always been challenging to make people laugh, but the job has become tougher in the social media age, where everyone is exposed to funny reels, memes and stand-up acts.

After 'Bhooth Bangla', Akshay is gearing up for the release of the comedy film 'Welcome To The Jungle'. The new film is part of the 'Welcome' franchise and is set to be released in theatres on Friday.

"It has become much more challenging. Today, there are reels, memes and comedy content everywhere. But comedy is like a huge river; it never dries up. There are so many forms of comedy. There's physical comedy, situational comedy, slapstick comedy and dark humour," Akshay told PTL.

The 58-year-old actor said today movies are not the only source of entertainment for people. "There are countless ways of making people laugh. If you open 'Instagram', you'll find endless memes and



He said today movies are not the only source of entertainment for people

funny videos. People consume comedy every day. There are so many comedy shows and talented stand-up comedians creating fresh material. But making people laugh remains one of the most difficult things to do. People often underestimate comedy. I have tremendous respect for stand-up comedians. Standing alone in front of an audience and making people

laugh is incredibly difficult." 'Welcome To The Jungle' revolves around a group of gangsters, criminals and quirky characters whose paths cross in a border-area jungle. What begins as a film-shoot-like operation turns into a series of absurd misadventures involving crime, confusion and action-packed situations. It will see Akshay leading a cast that includes over 30 actors, including Suneil Shetty, Paresch Rawal, Raveena Tandon, Arshad Warsi, Lara Dutta and many more.

The recently released trailer features several self-deprecating moments and Akshay said he enjoys being the centre of the joke.

"I think making fun of yourself is much better than making fun of somebody else. If I make fun of another person, there's not much joy in it. But if I joke about myself, that's far healthier."





DELHI TRANSCO LIMITED

NOTICE INVITING e-TENDERS

Delhi Transco Ltd, a Government of NCT of Delhi Undertaking, invites online tender for the work :

Tender No. T25R220484: Design, Engineering, Supply, Erection, Jointing, Testing and Commissioning of 400/220/66kV GIS Tikrikhurd Sub-Station with complete civil works & automation on Turnkey Basis.

For complete details of the tender please visit following websites :- <https://govtprocurement.delhi.gov.in> (Tender ID No. 2026_DTL_294145_1) and www.dtl.gov.in with Unique No. DTL-0060-240626

Last date for bid submission:- **18.08.2026, at 01.30 P.M.**

All Corrigendum/Addendum/ Amendments/Date of Extension/ Clarifications etc. to this e-tender will be hosted on the above website only. Bidders should regularly visit website to keep themselves updated.



DELHI TRANSCO LIMITED

NOTICE INVITING e-TENDERS

Delhi Transco Ltd, a Government of NCT of Delhi Undertaking, invites online tender for the work :

Tender No. T25R220474: Design, Engineering, Supply, Laying, Jointing, Testing and Commissioning of 220kV D/C 1x1200 sq.mm. U/G XLPE Cable from 220kV IP Substation to 220kV Rajghat Substation on turnkey basis.

For complete details of the tender please visit following websites :- <https://govtprocurement.delhi.gov.in> ((Tender ID No. 2026_DTL_285876_1) and www.dtl.gov.in with Unique No. DTL-0059-240626

Last date for bid submission:- **11.08.2026, at 01.30 P.M.**

All Corrigendum/Addendum/ Amendments/Date of Extension/ Clarifications etc. to this e-tender will be hosted on the above website only. Bidders should regularly visit website to keep themselves updated.



Jammu & Kashmir Bank Limited

Unit No. 101-102, U & V Block DDA Market, Shalimar Bagh Delhi-110088

T + 91 (0)11 27488364 E : smbagh@jkbmail.com W www.jkbank.net

POSSESSION NOTICE

Notice under Section 13 (4) of the SARFAESI ACT, 2002 read with Rule 8 (1) of the Security (Enforcement) Interest Rules, 2002

Whereas Mr. Mohammad Zahid as the Authorized Officer of the Jammu & Kashmir Bank Limited under the Securitization and Reconstruction of Financial Assets and Enforcement of Security Interest (SARFAESI) Act, 2002, and in exercise of powers under section 13(2) of the said Act read with Rule 3 of the Security Interest (Enforcement) Rules 2002, issued Demand Notice dated **04.11.2025** thereby calling upon the Borrower namely **Mr. Tapan Prakash and Gunjan Kumari** to repay an amount of **Rs.59,09,666.98 (Rupees Fifty Nine Lakhs Nine Thousand Six Hundred Sixty Six and Paise Ninety Eight Only)** being the balance outstanding as on **31.10.2025** in the accounts of the Borrower, within 60 days from the date of the said notice together with the future interest and other charges thereon.

The said borrower having failed to repay the said amount, notice is hereby given to the said borrower in particular and the public in general that the undersigned being authorized officer of the J & K Bank Ltd. has taken possession of the mortgage property described herein below, in exercise of the powers conferred on me under section 13 (4) of the said Act read with Rule 8 of the said Rules, on this the **24th day of June of the year 2026.**

The said borrowers in particular and the public in general are hereby cautioned against dealing with the said property in any manner whatsoever and any Dealings with the said property will be subject to the charge of the **J&K Bank Limited** for the amount in aggregating to **Rs. 62,88,363.98/- (Rupees Sixty Two Lakhs Eighty Eight Thousand Three Hundred Sixty Three and Paise Ninety Eight Only)** together with future interest thereon from **01.06.2026** and other charges incurred or to be incurred.

The borrower's attention is invited to the provisions of Sub-section (8) of Section 13 of the Act, in respect of the time available, to redeem the secured assets.

Description of the Immovable Property

Equitable Mortgage of Entire Second Floor with Roof/Terrace rights out of built up property, built on Freehold MLU Plot no. 21, Area measuring 100 Sq Meters, situated at Block EP, Pocket 3, Bindapur, Dwarka, New Delhi

Date : 24.06.2026 **Mr. Mohammad Zahid**
Place : Delhi **Authorized Officer**

Registered office Corporate Headquarters M.A.Road, Srinagar 190001 Kashmir, India **T +91 (0)194 2481 930-35**
F +91 (0)194 248 1928 CIN: L65110JK1938SGC000048
E info@jkbmail.com W www.jkbank.net



NORTHERN RAILWAY

OPEN E-TENDER NOTICE

The Sr. Divisional Engineer-III, Northern Railway, Delhi Division invites E-Tender for the following work.

- 1 Name of work:** Annual Zone work for PE 30/6/2026 for repair to service building & station building in the section of JE/Yamuna Bridge & SSB in the section of SSE/WDL/Line under ADEN/DLI.
- 2 Approx. cost of work:** Rs. 1,49,99,371.98/- (Rupees One Crore Forty Nine Lakh Ninety Nine Thousand Three Hundred Seventy One and Ninety Eight Paise only)
- 3 Earnest Money to be deposited :** Rs. 3,00,000.00/- (Rupees Three Lakh Only)
- 4 Cost of tender document :** Rs. 0.00/-
- 5 Date & Time of submission of tender bid and opening of tender :** 22.07.2026 @15:00 Hrs.
- 6 Website particulars** where complete details of tender documents can be seen : www.irops.gov.in
- 7 Allocation :** 04-410-32

* The tenderer/s must be registered on the Indian Railway E-Procurement system (IREPS) site i.e. www.irops.gov.in for participating in the e-tender system. * For all terms and conditions please refer tender document. * No manual offers are acceptable. * Cost of tender document and Earnest money will be acceptable through net banking or payment gateway only.

No.: 128-W/280/E-Tender Notice/NIT/30/2026-27/W-3 Dated:- 22.06.2026 2173/26

SERVING CUSTOMERS WITH A SMILE

PROCLAMATION REQUIRING THE APPEARANCE OF A PERSON ACCUSED

See Section 82 Cr. P.C. / 84 BNSS

Whereas complaint has been made before me that accused person **Sher Singh @ Sheru S/o Jagdish R/o H. No. D-25, Bhagya Vihar, Mubarakpur Dabas, Delhi** has Committed (or is suspected to have committed) the offence in case **FIR No. 1323/2017 U/s 33 Delhi Excise Act, P.S. Aman Vihar, Delhi** and it has been returned to a warrant of arrest thereupon issued that the said accused **Sher Singh @ Sheru** cannot be found and whereas it has been shown to my satisfaction that the said accused **Sher Singh @ Sheru** has absconded (or is concealing himself to avoid the service of the said warrant).

Proclamation is hereby made that the said accused **Sher Singh @ Sheru** of case **FIR No. 1323/2017 U/s 33 Delhi Excise Act, P.S. Aman Vihar, Delhi** is required to appear before this Court to answer the said complaint on or before **31.07.2026**.

By Order
Ms. Shagun
Judicial Magistrate First Class
North West, Court No. 109, 1st Floor
Rohini Courts, Delhi

DP/8032/RD/2026 (Court Matter)

PROCLAMATION REQUIRING THE APPEARANCE OF ACCUSED PERSON

See Section 82 Cr.P.C.

Whereas complaint has been made before me that accused **Kubra International Through Prop. D. Fairoze Ahmad, R/o Arbina Enterprises 11115-B, Gali Tant Wail, Motia Khan, Motia Khan, Pahar Ganj, Delhi** has committed (or is suspected to have committed) the offence in case **CC No. 516036/2016, U/s 356/379/34 IPC, P.S. DBG Road, Delhi** and it has been returned to a warrant of arrest thereupon issued that the said **Kubra International Through Prop. D. Fairoze Ahmad** cannot be found and whereas it has been shown to my satisfaction that the said **Kubra International Through Prop. D. Fairoze Ahmad** has absconded (or is concealing himself to avoid the service of the said warrant).

Proclamation is hereby made that the said **Kubra International Through Prop. D. Fairoze Ahmad Kumar** accused of **CC No. 516036/2016, U/s 356/379/34 IPC, P.S. DBG Road, Delhi** is required to appear before this Court to answer the said complaint on or before **30.07.2026**.

By Order - Ms. Preeti Rajoria
Judicial Magistrate First Class-07
Room No. 32, Tis Hazari Courts, Delhi

DP/8245/CD/2026

PROCLAMATION REQUIRING THE APPEARANCE OF ACCUSED PERSON

See Section 82 CrPC / 84 Bhartiya Nagarik Suraksha Sanhita, 2023

Whereas complaint has been made before me that accused person **ARTI W/o Sonu @ Sunny, R/o Kh. No. 376, Block-J, Gali No.-3, Khadda Colony, Swaroop Nagar, Delhi**, has committed (or is suspected to have committed) the offence in **FIR No.: 117/23, U/S 33/38 Delhi Excise Act, PS Swaroop Nagar, Outer North Distt., Delhi** and it has been returned to a warrant of arrest thereupon issued that the said accused **ARTI** cannot be found, and whereas it has been shown to my satisfaction that the said accused **ARTI** has absconded (or is concealing herself to avoid the service of the said warrant);

Proclamation is hereby made that **ARTI** the said accused of **FIR No.: 117/23, U/S 33/38 Delhi Excise Act, PS Swaroop Nagar, Outer North Distt., Delhi**, is required to appear before this Court to answer the said complaint on or before **27.07.2026**.

By Order
Sh. Sahil Gupta
Judicial Magistrate First Class-07, (North), Court No.-06, Ground Floor, Rohini Courts, Delhi

DP/8558/ON/2026 (Court Matter)



NORTH CENTRAL RAILWAY

Tender Notice No. : 4220262027 Date : 22.06.2026

E-Tender Notice

Divisional Railway Manager (Engineering)/ North Central Railway/ Prayagraj, for and on behalf of the President of India, invites the following E-Tenders on prescribed form for the following works up to 13:30 hrs. on 15.07.2026. The details of the tenders are as under-

Tender No. : 105 **Approx Cost of Work (Rs.) : 20245193.53**

Name of Work : Combined Tender: (A) Construction of RPF Post at Phaphund under ADEN/ETW. (B) Construction of 20 bedded RPF barrack at Shikohabad under ADEN/ETW.

Bid security (Rs.) : 404900.00 **Completion Period : 09 months**

Date of Opening of tender : 15.07.2026

Similar work for Eligibility Criteria : Construction of Building

Tender No. : 106 **Approx Cost of Work (Rs.) : 19939202.65**

Name of Work : Provision of pathways at various stations in AAP-TDL section under SR.DEN/II/PRYJ.

Bid security (Rs.) : 398800.00 **Completion Period : 12 months**

Date of Opening of tender : 15.07.2026

Similar work for Eligibility Criteria : Any Civil Engineering Work.

Note : (1) The complete information along with tender document of above E-Tenders is available on website www.irops.gov.in up to 13:30 hrs. on the due date of tender opening i.e. 15.07.2026. The tender shall be opened at or after 15:00 hrs on due date of opening. (2) Bids other than in the form of E-Bids shall not be accepted against above Tenders. For this purpose, vendors are required to get themselves registered with IREPS website along with Digital Signature Certificates issued by CCA under IT Act-2000. (3) Rates entered into Financial Rate page and duly signed digitally shall be considered. Rates and any other financial entry in any other form/letter head if attached by vendors shall be straightaway ignored and shall not be considered. (4) **Tender Nos. 105 & 106** are having advertised value more than 50 Lakhs, therefore, Annexure-V & V (A) (Document Verification Certificates) is required. The supplier/contractor of goods and/or services would be subject to GST Act and Rules as applicable from time to time. (5) This tender notice has also been uploaded on www.ncr.indianrailways.gov.in (6) In case of any difficulty/helpdesk available on the website of IREPS may be approached. (7) Tender online can be submitted up to 13:30 hrs. on 15.07.2026. (8) E-Tender Forms shall be issued free of cost to all tenderers. (9) For tender nos. 105 & 106: The tenderers have to submit necessary documents in compliance of clause 10 to 18 (Part-I) of IRGC-2022 (Works matter) mandatorily, otherwise their offer will be considered as Incomplete Offer and accordingly shall not be considered. 1423/26 (C)

[North central railways](http://www.ncr.indianrailways.gov.in) www.ncr.indianrailways.gov.in ncr@cpnrcr

PROCLAMATION REQUIRING THE APPEARANCE OF ACCUSED PERSON

See Section 82 Cr.P.C / 84 Bharatiya Nagarik Suraksha Sanhita

Whereas complaint has been made before me that accused person **Mohd. Shamim S/o Mohd. Dhannu R/o T-86, Vijay Choudhary Ka Makan, Nafisha Masjid, Sarai Kalen Khan New Delhi** has committed (or is suspected to have committed) the offence case **FIR No. 352/2020 u/s 25/54/59 Arms Act & 349/2020 u/s 324 IPC at P.S. Hazrat Nizamuddin, New Delhi** and it has been returned to a warrant of arrest thereupon issued that the said **Mohd. Shamim** cannot be found and whereas it has been shown to my satisfaction that the said **Mohd. Shamim** has absconded (or is concealing himself to avoid the service of the said warrant). Proceeding u/s 82 Cr.P.C / 84 Bharatiya Nagarik Suraksha Sanhita has been initiated in the case. Proclamation is hereby made that the said **Mohd. Shamim** accused of **FIR No. 352/2020 u/s 25/54/59 Arms Act & 349/2020 u/s 324 IPC at P.S. Hazrat Nizamuddin, New Delhi** is required to appear before this Court to answer the said complaint on **31.07.2026**.

By Order: Sh. Manuj Kaushal,
Judicial Magistrate First Class-03, (South-East)
Room No. 512,
Saket Court, New Delhi

DP/8489/SE/2026

CHHATTISGARH STATE POWER GENERATION CO. LTD.
(A Govt. of Chhattisgarh Undertaking)

No. 03-03/ TN-134/899 Raipur, Dtd 23/06 /2026

E-TENDER NOTICE NO. TN-134/2026-27

Online bids are invited for Supply/ work as mentioned below:-

S. No.	Tender no. /RFx no.	Description	Submission Date & time
1.	DW-171/26-27 8100052246 (With RLA)	Engagement of a Liaisoning Agency for Monitoring of Coal Loading, Rake Movement, Coordination with SECL & Railways, and Supervision of LDCC/TRS Supply System for DSPM TPS Korba East, ABV TPS Marwa & HTPS Korba West	03.07.2026 Up to 15:00 Hrs
2	HW-172/26-27 8100052330 (With RLA)	Supply & Dozing operation of Coal Additive (SUODOAD) in CSPGCL Thermal Power Station(West).	13.07.2026 Up to 15:00 Hrs
3	DW-173/26-27 8100052378 (Without RLA)	Deployment of Private Security Personnel for DSPM TPS, Korba East and KTPS, Korba East	17.07.2026 Up to 15:00 Hrs

For details please visit our website <https://cspe.co.in> or e-bidding portal:- <https://ebidding.cspcl.co.in:50724/irj/portal>

SAVE ELECTRICITY EXECUTIVE DIRECTOR(S&P-GEN) samvad48259/1 CSPGCL,RAIPUR



SHREE SAIBABA SANSTHAN TRUST, SHIRDI
At.Post. Shirdi, Tal- Rahata, Dist. A.Nagar - 423 109
Phone No.(02423) 258500 / 258867
(Website - www.sai.org.in) E-mail – sanitation.sai.org.in

TENDER NOTICE

E-Tenders are invited on Outsource basis for Shree Saibaba Darshan Complex Work of Housekeeping Cleaning and Gardening Including Machinery etc. as well as mechanized housekeeping for Shree Saibaba Darshan Complex the duration of 2026-28. The tender details will be available on <https://mahatenders.gov.in> for downloading and terms & conditions visit our website www.sai.org.in.

Tender Publish starts date 25/06/2026 Time 11:00 am.

Tender submission end date 09/07/2026 Time 05:00 pm.

Goraksha Gadilkar, I.A.S
Chief Executive Officer,

Dgipr/2026-27/1288



ICICI Bank

Branch Office: ICICI Bank Limited Plot No-23, Shal Tower, 3rd Floor, New Rohtak Road, Karol Bagh, New Delhi-110005

The following borrower(s) has/have defaulted in the repayment of principal and interest towards the Loan facility(ies) availed from ICICI Bank. The Loan(s) has/have been classified as Non-Performing Asset(s) (NPA). A Notice was issued to them under Section 13(2) of the Securitisation and Re-construction of Financial Assets and Enforcement of Security Interest Act, 2002, at their last known addresses. However, it has not been served and are therefore being notified by way of this Public Notice.

Sr. No.	Name of the Borrower/ Co-Borrower/ Guarantor/ (Loan Account Number) & Address	Description of Secured Asset to be enforced	Date of Notice sent/ Outstanding as on Date of Notice	NPA Date
1.	Poonam Devi/ Sumit Maan (LBNO00005797751) & Flat No. 2039, Tower F, 6th Avenue Gaur City G.R., Noida (West) Gautam Buddha Nagar Noida Surjpur - 201306	Flat No. A101 "Govardhan Heights" Tower/ Block No. "A", Khosra No. 687/ 1076 Part. 687 Part- 688/ 1147, Jaishnghpura Boss Sangarner Jaipur, Rajasthan, Jaipur- 302026	26/05/2026 Rs. 11,56,545/-	05/03/2026

These steps are being taken for substituted service of Notice. The above borrower/s and/or guarantor/s (as applicable) is/are advised to make the outstanding payment within 60 days from the date of publishing this Notice. Else, further steps will be taken as per the provisions of the Securitisation and Re-construction of Financial Assets and Enforcement of Security Interest Act, 2002.

Date: June 25, 2026
Place: Delhi/Ncr

Sincerely Authorised Officer,
For ICICI Bank Ltd.



ICICI Bank

Branch Office: ICICI Bank Limited Plot No-23, Shal Tower, 3rd Floor, New Rohtak Road, Karol Bagh, New Delhi-110005

The following borrower(s) has/have defaulted in the repayment of principal and interest towards the Loan facility(ies) availed from ICICI Bank. The Loan(s) has/have been classified as Non-Performing Asset(s) (NPA). A Notice was issued to them under Section 13(2) of the Securitisation and Re-construction of Financial Assets and Enforcement of Security Interest Act, 2002, at their last known addresses. However, it has not been served and are therefore being notified by way of this Public Notice.

Sr. No.	Name of the Borrower/ Co-Borrower/ Guarantor/ (Loan Account Number) & Address	Description of Secured Asset to be enforced	Date of Notice sent/ Outstanding as on Date of Notice	NPA Date
1.	Khurram Jamal Al Nasir/ Shaheel Ahmed/ LBNO00001980915/ H.No. D 235, Abul Fazal Enclave Jamia Nagar Okhla, New Delhi, Delhi- 110025	Apartment No. GD10140202, 2nd Floor, Tower-14, Allotement No. B019591, Situated in Greater Noida District Gautam Budh Nagar, Noida U.P.- 201307	06-06-2026 Rs. 40,06,596/-	13-Apr-2026
2.	Amit Singla/ Khushboo Kumari/ TBNO00006627097/ C1-305, Sanskriti Apartment, Sector-1, Bishrakh, Greater Noida West Buddha Nagar, Uttar Pradesh, Noida- 201306	Residential House No. 55, Block- D, Sector- Beta-01, Allotement No. B019591, Situated in Greater Noida District Gautam Budh Nagar, Noida U.P.- 201307	02-06-2026 Rs. 48,21,582.27/-	06-Apr-2026
3.	Jagdish Kumar/ Priyanka Kumari/ LBEO0000619654/ 29 Surikalan 1 Surikalan 1 Ps. Surit The Mant, Uttar Pradesh, Mathura-281205	Residential Flat/ Unit Bearing No. 21135, 21st Floor, Block Chestnut , (Having Super Area 1100 Sq Ft. & Covered Area 900 Sq Ft) Along With One Single Covered Car Parking Space In The "Mahagun Mywoods" Built On Plot No. GH-04, Situated At Sector- 16C, Greater Noida District Gautam Budh Nagar Uttar Pradesh- 201318	05-06-2026 Rs. 33,12,589/-	03-Feb-2026
4.	Shubham Singh/ Ayush Singh/ LBGHZ00006224673/ TBGHZ00006219491/ H.No. 64 Ground Floor, sector 22, Noida Gautam Buddha Nagar Uttar Pradesh, Noida- 201301	Studio Apartment No.1414 On 14th Floor, Kaveri City Center Situated At C-06 Delta One, Uttar Pradesh, Greater Noida- 201310	05-06-2026 Rs. 49,80,052/- Rs. 18,30,116.54/-	11-Mar-2026
5.	Raginee Singh/ Annapurna Singh/ LBNO00003084490/ 63/1 41 Shivkuti Allahabad, Near Pratiksh Swasthya Kendra, Allahabad, Uttar Pradesh, Allahabad- 211004	Flat No. D-2004, 20th Floor, Ratan Pearls Situated At GH-01D, Sector-16, Uttar Pradesh, Greater Noida (West)- 201307	30-05-2026 Rs. 17,35,430/-	24-Feb-2026

These steps are being taken for substituted service of Notice. The above borrower/s and/or guarantor/s (as applicable) is/are advised to make the outstanding payment within 60 days from the date of publishing this Notice. Else, further steps will be taken as per the provisions of the Securitisation and Re-construction of Financial Assets and Enforcement of Security Interest Act, 2002.

Date: June 25, 2026
Place: Delhi/ Ncr

Sincerely Authorised Officer,
For ICICI Bank Ltd.



ICICI Bank

Branch Office: ICICI Bank Limited Plot No-23, Shal Tower, 3rd Floor, New Rohtak Road, Karol Bagh, New Delhi- 110005

The Authorised ICICI Bank Officer under the Securitisation, Reconstruction of Financial Assets and Enforcement of Security Interest Act, 2002 and in exercise of the powers conferred under section 13(12) read with Rule 3 of the Security Interest (Enforcement) Rules 2002, issued Demand Notices to the borrower(s) mentioned below, to repay the amount mentioned in the Notice within 60 days from the date of receipt of the said Notice. Having failed to repay the amount, the Notice is issued to the borrower and the public in general that the undersigned has taken possession of the property described below, by exercising powers conferred on him/her under Section 13(4) of the said Act read with Rule 8 of the said rules on the below-mentioned dates. The borrower in particular and the public in general are hereby cautioned not to deal with the property. Any dealings with the property will be subject to charges of ICICI Bank Limited.

Sr. No.	Name of the Borrower(s)/ Loan Account Number	Description of Property/ Date of Physical Possession	Date of Demand Notice/ Amount in Demand Notice (Rs)	Name of Branch
1.	Mohit Singh/ Suman Singh/ LBGHZ00002865033	H.No M-146, Ground Floor, Sec-23 Sanjay Nagar, Ghaziabad/ June 23, 2026	August 29,2022/ Rs.10,91,710/-	Delhi/ NCR

The above-mentioned borrower(s)/guarantor(s) is/are hereby issued a 30 day Notice to repay the amount, else the mortgaged properties will be sold after 30 days from the date of publishing this Notice, as per the provisions under Rules 8 and 9 of Security Interest (Enforcement) Rules 2002.

Date: June 25, 2026
Place: Delhi/Ncr

Sincerely Authorised Officer
For ICICI Bank Ltd.

GOVERNMENT OF MAHARASHTRA
Public Works Division, Ahilyanagar
Phone No. 0214/2325334 & 0241/2325086

E-TENDER NOTICE NO.05 FOR 2026-27 (Online)

e-mail- ahmednagar.ec@mahapwd.gov.in

online E-Tenders in B-1 Form for the following works invited by Executive Engineer Public Works Division, Ahilyanagar (Phone No. 0241-2325334/2325086) From the Competent and Interested contractors .(Not Necessary Registered with P.W.D.) If Global Company having its Branch/Sub Company in Indian they can Participate in Tender.

Executive Engineer, Public Works Division, Ahilyanagar who reserves the right to reject any or all tenders without assigning any reason there fore.

Sr.N o.	Name of Work	Estimated Amount in Lakhs	Estimated Amount in Words
1	Improvements to Parner Supa road SH 69 to vadner Haweli Ralegan Siddhi road MDR-218 Km 3/800 to 11/600/Tal Parner.	Rs.817.00 Lakhs	Rs.Eight Crore Seventeen Lakhs
2	Improvement to Kedgaon Sonewadi Akolner Ghospuri Chikhali Road MDR-54 Km 4/500 to 9/00 (Part-Kedgaon to Akolner) Tal.Dist-Ahilyanagar	Rs.540.00 Lakhs	Rs.Five Crore Forty Lakhs .
3	Construction of Causeway on Tal.Border Shrigonda to Mhatarpimpri to Dist.Border road Vr.59 at Km.4/00 Tal.Nagar (Near Shri Krishna Temple Mahanubhav Ashram) Tal.Dist.A.nagar	Rs.648.00 Lakhs	Rs.Six Crore Forty Eight Lakhs
4	Construction of Major Bridge on Dighol Malewadi Road (VR-23) km 3/200 Tal.Jamkhed Dist. Ahilyanagar	Rs.618.00 Lakhs	Rs.Six Crore Eighteen Lakhs
5	Concreting & Improvement to Kharekarjune Hingangaon Nimgaon Wagha Kedgaon Wakodi Walunj Road (M.D.R.170) Km. 17/220 to 19/400 Tal.Ahilyanagar	Rs.565.00 Lakhs	Rs.Five Crore Sixty Five Lakhs
6	Concreting & Improvement to Pune Ahilyanagar Road (Old S.H.60) Km. 118/800 to 119/800	Rs.1215.00 Lakhs	Rs.Twelve Crore Fifteen Lakhs

Tender sale start Date - 25/06/2026 to 02/07/2026, at 18:00 Pm, Tender Opening Dt. 03/07/2026, Pre-Bid Meeting, Dt.29/06/2026 at 12.30 Hrs. In the Office of Chief Engineer, P.W.Region Office, Nashik

The details of works are provided on the websites as below.
1. www.mahapwd.com.
2. mahatenders.gov.in
(Change if any in above Schedule can be seen on above website)

Executive Engineer, Public Works Division Ahilyanagar

Dgipr /2026-27/1286



NORTH CENTRAL RAILWAY

No.JHS/T.D./Dra.Se./Tender/Notice/149 Dated 22.06.2026

E-Tendering Tender Notice

Sr. Divisional Electrical Engineer (Traction Distribution) N.C. Railway, Jhansi for and behalf of President of India invites sealed "Open Tender" through on Line (E-Tendering) for the following work.

S.N.: 1. E-Tender No.: JHS-TD-TENDER-2026-12. Description of work: Supply and Erection of Monkey Anti-Climbing device in Monkey prone area to prevent climbing of Monkey on Traction installation structures in Jhansi Division. **Approx Cost (₹): 1,03,04,871.71 Earnest Money/Bid Security (₹): 2,06,100.00**

Date of closing Tender: 15.07.2026, 15:00 pm.

S.N.: 2. E-Tender No.: JHS-TD-TENDER-2026-8R. Description of work: OHE modification work in connection with Longer loop line on 3rd line at BURHPURA Station in Jhansi-Bina section of Jhansi division. **Approx Cost (₹): 67,01,503.99 Earnest Money/Bid Security (₹): 1,34,000.00**

Date of closing Tender: 17.07.2026, 15:00 pm.

Date of completion/period from issue acceptance letter: For S.N.: 1 & 2:- 09 Months

(1) Tender online can be submitted up to 15.00 hrs on 15.07.2026 & 17.07.2026.
(2) For full details and submission of bid please see the Indian Railways website www.irops.gov.in. 1430/26 (MG)

[North central railways](http://www.ncr.indianrailways.gov.in) ncr@cpnrcr www.ncr.indianrailways.gov.in



NORTH CENTRAL RAILWAY

E-TENDER NOTICE NO. 10/2026 Date: 22.06.2026

E-TENDER NOTICE

Sr. DSTE/North Central Railway, Agra acting for and on behalf of the President of India invites "Open Tender" through Online only (E-Tendering) for the following work:

E-Tender NO.: AGRA-ST-2026-24 Approx. Cost of work: 1,00,81,423 .82

Name of work: Provision of new conference system along with Screen and PA system in the Govardhan Conference Room in DRM office of Agra Division.

Tender closing date: 16.07.2026. For full details and submission of bid please see the Indian Railway Website www.irops.gov.in. Bidders will be able to submit their original/ revised bids through web portal www.irops.gov.in up to 15:00 hrs on above mentioned date. Manual offers are not allowed against this tender and any such manual offer received shall be ignored. 1426/26 (ADM)

[North central railways](http://www.ncr.indianrailways.gov.in) ncr@cpnrcr www.ncr.indianrailways.gov.in

PROCLAMATION REQUIRING THE APPEARANCE OF ACCUSED PERSON

See Section Cr.P.C / 84 Bharatiya Nagarik Suraksha Sanhita, 2023

Whereas complaint has been made before me that the accused **Alok, S/o. Hariom Gupta, R/o.: B-1438, Jahangir Puri, Delhi** has committed (or is suspected to have committed) the offence in a case vide **Case Reg. No.1.1.2014 3604/2016 U/S 200 Cr.PC** registered at **P.S Jahangir Puri, North West District, Delhi** and it has been returned on a warrant of arrest thereupon issued stating that the said accused **Alok** could not be found and whereas it has been shown to my satisfaction that accused **Alok** is absconded (or is concealing himself to avoid the service of the said warrant).

Proclamation is hereby made that the said **Alok**, accused of **Case Reg. No.1.1.2014 3604/2016 U/S 200 Cr.PC, P.S Jahangir Puri, North West District, Delhi** is required to appear before the court to answer the said complaint on or before **06.08.2026**.

By Order, Ms. Jyoti Nair,
Judicial Magistrate First Class-07,
DP/8496/NW/2026 North District, Court No.6, First Floor, (Court Matter) Rohini Courts, Delhi.



AROUND THE WORLD



BUZZER ROUND



NEWS & VIEWS

» India ranks 13th in AI-economy readiness, but skills gap threatens growth: QS World Future Skills Index 2027

» IIT Hyderabad launches 2-month nuclear technology orientation programme

» IIM Lucknow collaborates with NIDM to advance disaster risk reduction and research collaboration

» IIIT-B workshop focuses on the next phase of digital public infrastructure

Q) WHICH COUNTRY HAS WON THE FIFA WORLD CUP MAXIMUM TIME?

Send us your replies to careersmp22@gmail.com. We shall publish the names of the first 3 correct entries in next week's edition

Answer to our June 18 edition question: **Faqir Chand Kohli**

Correct answers were sent by: **Sayantani Biswas, Ratul Singha, Pooja Basu**

NEWS

IIT Madras celebrated the achievements of 1,460 learners who became eligible to receive degrees and diplomas through its BS Degree Programmes at a convocation ceremony held on campus recently. The BS Degree Programmes currently have over 42,000 active learners from across India and abroad, making it one of the world's largest non-campus degree initiatives.

Achieving a major global recognition, 67 faculty members of NIT Rourkela have been featured in the prestigious SciRank Global World's Top 5% Scientists List. From NIT Rourkela, researchers from the Department of Chemistry accounted for the highest number of entries in the list.

AI, YOUTUBE & MOCK TESTS

NEW-AGE TOOLKIT FOR INDIA'S ENTRANCE EXAM ASPIRANTS

Rising costs and smarter technology are changing how India's aspirants prepare for entrance examinations

URJA SAHA

For many years, success in India's highly competitive entrance examinations depended largely on premium coaching centres, study materials, rigorous testing, experienced faculty and long hours of self-study. Students and parents were often made to believe that these top-tier coaching institutes were the only gateway to success in examinations such as JEE Main, JEE Advanced, WBJEE, NEET-UG, CLAT and CAT. Enrolling their wards in these coaching centres became one of the biggest financial commitments for many parents.

Then, in 2020, Covid-19 happened. While the world would never be the same again, neither would the education system. The education ecosystem underwent a dramatic transformation with the rise of online learning. Platforms such as YouTube, Skillshare and MasterClass democratised education in ways that traditional institutions had never anticipated.

For the longest time, coaching institutes were considered the gold standard for learning and cracking entrance examinations. However, this traditional model is now being challenged by the rise of video-based learning amid increasing educational costs and the rapid proliferation of Artificial Intelligence (AI). It is no surprise that learners, especially younger generations, are increasingly turning to YouTube and digital platforms alongside, and sometimes instead of, coaching classes.

AI chatbots, YouTube tutorials, social media study communities, Telegram channels, digital flashcards and online mock-test platforms are becoming integral parts of exam preparation for aspirants appearing for examinations such as UPSC, JEE, NEET, CUET, UGC-NET, CLAT and various university entrance tests.

Kolkata's Souritra Roy (20) cracked the WB JEE without enrolling in any coaching centre. His elder brother had joined a prestigious coaching institute in Kolkata to prepare for JEE Main, but Souritra wanted to chart his own path. From YouTube tutorials and online study materials to Claude,

he made sure he had all the support he needed. Ranked 350 in WBJEE, Souritra is now pursuing BTech in Electronics and Communication Engineering at a prestigious university in Kolkata. "I wanted to give it a try and prove myself. I researched extensively online and learnt from YouTube tutorials. I also followed a self-paced study schedule, which helped me a lot," said Roy.

The shift reflects a broader transformation in education,

driven by increased internet access and the growing availability of digital learning resources. Students now use AI-powered platforms such as ChatGPT, Gemini, Claude and others to simplify complex concepts, generate practice questions, summarise lengthy chapters and create personalised study schedules. Meanwhile, YouTube has emerged as a virtual classroom, offering free lectures and study materials from experienced educators and toppers alike.

Social media platforms such as Instagram, Telegram and Reddit have also become popular among aspirants. Students exchange notes, discuss current affairs, share preparation strategies and motivate one another through online study groups. For many candidates preparing independently without access to expensive coaching centres, these communities provide both academic support and a sense of belonging.

Meanwhile, mock tests have evolved into sophisticated digital tools, many of which are now AI-enhanced. Several platforms offer detailed performance analytics that help students identify weak areas, track progress and compare their performance against thousands of peers nationwide. Experts believe that regular practice through mock examinations can improve time management and exam temperament. Platforms supported by educational institutions and technology companies are increasingly offering such services for examinations including JEE, NEET and CUET.

Riya Dey, a UGC-NET aspirant, said, "I initially considered joining a coaching institute, but the fees were simply beyond my budget. Today, I rely on a combination of AI tools, YouTube lectures, social media study groups and online mock tests for my preparation." Dey believes that these resources allow her to study at her own pace while saving both time and money.

"For students like me, who may not be able to afford expensive coaching programmes, technology has made quality exam preparation much more accessible," she said.

The most crucial advantage of AI-assisted learning is its affordability. In a country where coaching fees for examinations such as UPSC, JEE and NEET can run into several lakhs annually, many students from economically weaker backgrounds struggle to access quality guidance. AI tools, free YouTube lectures, open-access study materials and low-cost mock-test platforms are helping bridge that gap. With nothing more than a smartphone and an internet connection, students can access personalised explanations, doubt-solving assistance, study plans and revision tools that were once available primarily through expensive coaching institutes.

However, many educators believe that technology works best when it complements rather than replaces traditional methods. Reading standard textbooks, solving previous years' papers, revising regularly and maintaining discipline continue to be the strongest predictors of success. Online communities of aspirants often echo this view, noting that while AI can help with revision planning and doubt-solving, consistent effort ultimately determines performance.

There are also concerns about misinformation. Social media often circulates unverified study tips, rumours about examination patterns and inaccurate content. Excessive screen time and constant notifications can further distract students from focused study sessions.

This is not to suggest that coaching institutes are being replaced by online tutorials. However, the landscape is certainly changing. Students now have alternative pathways to learning and exam preparation. Whether this model proves to be a sustainable long-term alternative remains to be seen. What is clear, however, is that students today have more choices than ever before. As India's examination ecosystem becomes increasingly digital, the role of AI and online learning is only expected to grow further.

BIT MESRA, IIT KHARAGPUR TEAM UP FOR RESEARCH

OUR CORRESPONDENT

BIT Mesra and IIT Kharagpur have signed a MoU to establish structured collaboration across research, academics, and institutional capacity-building. The agreement establishes a five-year framework, extendable by mutual consent, covering joint PhD supervision, shared laboratory access, and a range of collaborative academic and research activities. The MoU was signed by Prof Indra-nil Manna, Vice Chancellor, BIT Mesra, and Prof Suman Chakraborty, Director, IIT Kharagpur.

"The collaboration with IIT Kharagpur represents an important milestone in BIT Mesra's pursuit of academic excellence, impactful research, and innovation-led growth," said Prof Manna. The MoU spans joint supervision of Master's and PhD students, undergraduate and postgraduate research collaborations, student and faculty exchange, summer and winter internships, and joint submission of research proposals to national and international funding agencies. It also includes shared access to research facilities, faculty development programmes, staff and officer training, and joint academic activities such as seminars, workshops, GIAN courses, and micro-credit courses.

The signing brings together two institutions with roots in the decade immediately after Indian independence. BIT Mesra was established in 1955 and elevated to the status of a deemed university in 1986. IIT Kharagpur, founded in 1951, is the first of the IITs and is recognised as an Institute of National Importance.

Both institutions will also explore a joint integrated MTech -PhD programme and dual-degree pathways under the agreement. A Joint MoU Implementation Committee, comprising representatives from both institutions, will oversee progress with biannual reviews.

"The MoU will facilitate knowledge sharing, joint research initiatives, and capacity building, benefiting both institutions and the broader academic community," said Prof Chakraborty.

ADMISSION ALERT

MTech in Flood & Water Resources Management from IIT Guwahati

OUR CORRESPONDENT

IIT Guwahati is inviting applications for the second batch of MTech degree programme in Flood and Water Resources Management. Offered by the Department of Civil Engineering, this degree programme will be conducted in hybrid mode (online classes, labs and final exam on IIT Guwahati campus). It is designed to equip students with advanced knowledge and applied skills to address complex challenges related to water scarcity, climate variability, and sustainable development.

The application portal for the second batch is now open. A key feature of the program is that no GATE score is required to apply for the same. Candidates will be selected based on the written test/ interview conducted by the department. The application deadline ends on July 15, 2026 and the programme starts on August 10, 2026.

One requires a four-year Bachelor's degree (or equivalent) in Civil/Agricultural Engineering or Allied Disciplines with at least 60% marks or 6.0/10 CPI for this course. Also, a minimum one year of professional experience in water resource sector is also required.

KNOW THE DETAILS

- » THE PROGRAMME DURATION IS 2 YEARS, WHICH CAN BE EXTENDED UP TO 5 YEARS
- » IT WILL FOLLOW TRIMESTER-BASED SYSTEM, WITH EACH TERM HAVING 12 WEEKS OF INSTRUCTIONS
- » NO AGE OR LOCATION RESTRICTION FOR APPLICANTS
- » ALL LABORATORIES AND EXAMINATIONS WILL BE CONDUCTED ON IIT GUWAHATI CAMPUS

SCHOLARSHIP

UOW India offers scholarship for Business Analytics students

The application deadline is July 31, 2026

OUR CORRESPONDENT

The University of Wollongong, India, has announced the Merit Scholarship for their Bachelor of Business (Finance and Business Analytics), offering a 50% tuition fee reduction for the first year.

Applications for the upcoming intake are now open, and prospective students are encouraged to explore the scholarship opportunities as part of their admission process, as there is no separate application needed. Students must be commencing a Bachelor's

KNOW THE DETAILS

- » Scholarships available: **UNLIMITED**
- » Commencement: **TRIMESTER ONE 2026 (JULY 2026)**
- » Degree: **BACHELOR OF BUSINESS (FINANCE AND BUSINESS ANALYTICS)**

program at UOW India in 2026, have a WAM of 75% or above, or 70% in a competitive exam with a WAM 65% to avail the scholarship.

India's quest for economic leadership in changing world

Long-term economic leadership will depend on investments in human capital, technological innovation

DR INDRIKA DEB & PROF (DR) ANUPAM MITRA

India stands at a pivotal moment in its economic journey. At a time when the global economy is grappling with geopolitical tensions, technological disruption, climate challenges, and shifting trade dynamics, India finds itself uniquely positioned to emerge as a major driver of global growth.

According to projections from international financial institutions, India is expected to remain one of the world's fastest-growing major economies, with growth estimated at around 6.5 per cent in 2026. At a time when global growth is projected to remain close to 3 per cent, India's economic momentum reflects the strength of domestic demand, public infrastructure investment, digital transformation, and a rapidly expanding entrepreneurial ecosystem.

One of the most remarkable developments in recent years has been India's digital transformation. The country has successfully built one of the world's largest digital public infrastructures through initiatives such as Aadhaar, Unified Payments Interface (UPI), Digi Locker, and the Account Aggregator framework.

UPI transactions have crossed 18 billion transactions per month, making India a global leader in digital payments. Millions of indi-

viduals and small businesses now participate in the formal financial system through low-cost digital platforms. Artificial Intelligence is rapidly emerging as the defining technology of the 21st century. For India, AI presents a significant opportunity. The country possesses one of the world's largest pools of engineering and technology talent, a thriving start-up ecosystem, and a rapidly expanding digital economy. These strengths provide a strong foundation for AI adoption and innovation.

However, AI also presents critical policy challenges. Automation has the potential to alter employment patterns, particularly for routine and repetitive tasks. The challenge before India is not merely to adopt AI technologies but to prepare its workforce for an

increasingly digital future.

India's financial landscape is also undergoing a transformation. Investors are increasingly directing capital towards sectors associated with future growth, including technology, renewable energy, digital services, AI and advanced manufacturing.

The growing participation of retail investors, expansion of fintech platforms, and increasing financial inclusion are contributing to deeper and more dynamic capital markets. Increasingly, value creation is being driven not only by physical assets but also by intellectual property, innovation, data, and technological capabilities.

This shift reflects a broader transformation in the global economy. The most valuable

ENERGY SECURITY IN AN UNCERTAIN WORLD

Recent geopolitical tensions in West Asia have once again demonstrated the vulnerability of global energy markets. India imports more than 85 percent of its crude oil requirements, making energy security a critical economic concern. Rising energy costs can also place pressure on the country's fiscal and external balances.

Recognising these challenges, India has accelerated its transition toward renewable energy. Significant investments in solar energy, wind power, green hydrogen, battery storage, and electric mobility are reshaping the country's energy landscape.

economic assets of the future may not be natural resources or industrial facilities alone, but knowledge, creativity, and innovation.

The defining challenge for India over the next decade will be to transform economic growth into sustainable and inclusive prosperity. Strong GDP growth provides an important foundation, but long-term economic leadership will depend upon investments in human capital, technological innovation, institutional quality, and infrastructure. The future of economic power may still depend partly on oil, but for India, the pathway to prosperity will increasingly be paved by algorithms, innovation, and human ingenuity.

The authors are professors, Faculty of Commerce and Management St.Xavier's University, Kolkata